A Song to Come Home To

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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by Queen_of_Milktea

Summary

The freedom of college life has been perfect for Adora. But when she's forced to visit home for the holidays, she's confronted with her best friend who she hasn't spoken to for an entire year. One that she kissed the day she left.

Imagine a suburban neighbourhood, bike rides on wide roads, tree houses, reminiscing about high school parties and a 50s diner - all set in a nostalgic shade of sepia.

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TLDR: Holiday AU meets College AU. Adora's left for college. Catra stayed. They're gay.

Notes

Hi everyone,
Welcome to the fic. Just a disclaimer before I go any further. I should mention that this is set in an ambiguously-English Speaking town and virtually all locations will be made up. But in terms of college/university information, it'll be based on my own experiences as a (current but soon to be finishing) tertiary-education student. So if you're sitting here thinking "This is so inaccurate to my own experiences", universities/colleges around the world approach education differently, and this is based on the schooling I've completed.

Hope you all enjoy—I'm excited to write this!

Chapter 1

MOM: Are you coming home for Christmas darling?

The dreaded text. Adora couldn't believe it. *It actually came.*

Shit.

Fuck.

Adora scrambled to turn her phone on silent mode. She would've screamed if she wasn't in the middle of a library.

"What is it?" Glimmer asked, peering over her laptop. One that was littered with bright stickers from Op-Shops and concerts.

Adora's head shot up at her, eyes wide with concern. "It's my mom."

"What?!" her shout echoed throughout the library. She received a few looks and annoyed groans. She embarrassingly laid lower and whispered, "You guys never talk."

"I know!"

Everything was so perfect up until then. Ever since she moved out to college, she felt like she had finally found her place in the world. The people. The lifestyle. The campus. The freedom. Oh my god, the freedom. She loved all of it.

Except for the assessments. Those were awful. I mean, why else would she be here, in a study pod at 9PM, trying to finish off her 2500 word essay that's due tomorrow.

“I didn’t think she’d do it,” Adora said in disbelief, fiddling with her phone case. “I thought the snow storm last week would’ve turned her off.”

“At least you get a good Christmas feast, right?” Glimmer was met with Adora shaking her head aggressively.

“It’s dry turkey, overly sweet eggnog and no seasoning,”

“Okay that was my fault for assuming that white people can cook.”

Just on cue, Bow swerved into their spot, three coffees in his hands. He plopped them down in the middle of their desks. Though Adora hated her stupid assessment, she couldn’t help but to love this vibe. The three of them, tucked away in a little spot in the back corner of their college library; white boards surrounding them to make it ever so cosy.

“A black coffee for Adora,” Bow sang in a tone all too chipper for how late it was. He wriggled the cup from the cupholder. “A chai tea for Glimmer, and a matcha for me.”

They exchanged grateful thank yous and took them graciously into their hands. The heat warmed up their shivering-cold hands.

Glimmer took off the lid and blew over her tea. “And you’re from the Horde district, right?”

“Mhm,” she took a long sip. “Horone Hills to be specific.”

“Oh no you have to go back home?” Bow said with genuine concern, flipping open his laptop.

“Yeah, but it’s—”

“Do you need an excuse? I can pretend to break my arm,”

“Bow can pretend to break his arm,”

“I can pretend to break my arm.”

Adora laughed.

She didn’t know how she ended up so lucky. How she found such amazing friends like them. She met Glimmer on the very first day of college. Her introductory ARTS1000 class. She was running late (campus is grossly oversized), and she took the only empty chair at the very back of the classroom. That’s where she met Glimmer who had forgotten her notes back in her dorm room. Despite having completely different majors, they got along straight away, and eventually, Adora was introduced to Glimmer’s friend Bow. And the trio spent almost every day together.

“It’s okay. I’m sure it’ll be fine,” she dismissed, though there was admittedly a slight hesitation in her voice.

“But they’re like, culty there. Aren’t they?”

“Glimmer!”

“What? It’s true,” she took a sip of her drink. “Like, why do all the houses look the same? Also, it’s super suburban and there’s no shops but it’s so expensive! Why? It *has* to be money laundering, right?”

Adora chuckled, clicking casually on her keyboard to finish off her bibliography. “I mean, you’re not wrong.”

“When are you leaving?” Bow asked.

She thought for a second, “Probably tomorrow. I’m nearly finished with my final assessment so—”

“Wait,” he stopped, colour draining from his face. “You’ve finished your assessments…?”

“Yeah Bow. We’re arts majors,” Glimmer snickered. “We don’t do exams.”

“I. Have. Five,” Bow buried his face in his hands. “I’m not finishing for the next 5 weeks! *Aah.* I. Am. Stressed.”

“Well whose fault is it that they chose engineering?”

They all laughed, but Adora’s voice descended into realisation of what was coming. She dreaded the thought. She would need to pack that night, put on the chains on her car, and worst of all, talk to her mom. “...but yeah, I guess I’ll need to leave tomorrow.”

By the time she got around to the conclusion, her chest finally began to simmer. At least with the assessments out of the way, she could focus just on her family. And making sure that she could perfectly balance stress and biting her tongue. *2485 words* . *Good*

enough . Okay that last part might have been written with a little bit of help from ChatGPT but they’re not gonna know.

“I’m just going to submit this real quick…” she flicked through her tabs. “...and done! Okay, goodbye semester 2. I’m out!”

She slammed her laptop shut and was met with a congratulatory applause from her two friends.

“Was that for Intro to Latin?” Glimmer asked, nowhere near the end of her own essay.

“Nah, I submitted that last week. This was HSTY1002, Age of Empires,” Adora replied with a proud but exhausted smile.

“You know, you're the only person on earth who submits assessments a day early,”

“What can I say? I’m an overachiever,” she zipped her backpack shut. “I think I'm going to knock out the Latin units early so I can quickly finish my minor.”

“See, that's way too much work for me. I’m just going to go on exchange instead,” she chuckled. "No minor for me."

“That’s because you do a double major. Plus, it means I'll be stuck with *way* more history units for my major. And apparently HSTY1230 sucks and I'm doing that next so,” she threw her bag onto her back. “Anyways I’m heading off.”

“Good luck for tomorrow!”

“Yeah good luck for tomorrow Adora,”

“Please text us when you get there!”

“Of course.”

The winter night was cold. Deathly cold. Adora made her way over to her dorm room—situated down the main street and towards the east side of the campus. She stuck her hands into her pockets, feeling the rough air slap her across the face. Even with her puffer jacket and sweatpants, she could somehow feel the cold seeping through. It was going to be even colder back home. At least her campus was closer to the shore, the beach, so it wasn't as bad. Her hometown was essentially across the mountain. Way more inner land and so so cold.

Her dorm room was tall—pretty much a skyscraper compared to the houses that she was used to—and built from smooth sandstone and glass. It was beautiful and statuesque. Painfully expensive but her parents got that covered. She lived on the

eighth floor. High enough to see central campus. Low enough to rush to call dibs on the pool tables on ground floor commons.

She fiddled with her keys and forced her way into the room. She was thankful for how quiet her roommates were. She barely knew what they looked like, let alone their names. Other than their shared kitchen, they all had separate bedrooms and timetables, so it was pretty rare to run into each other.

Adora slumped onto her bed and took the deepest breath imaginable to try and muster up the courage to finally take that call. It was one call. *How hard could it be?*

When she checked her phone, she was met with 15 missed messages and 5 missed calls. It had been an hour.

She sighed, and dialled the number in. It rang twice before her mom answered.

"Honey?"

Adora groaned to herself silently. "Hi m—"

"Why didn't you answer the phone? I was worried sick about you,"

“I was trying to finish my assignment mom,”

“You always answer your mother. Always,” she heard a heavy sigh on the side. “Regardless, are you coming home for the holidays? I’m sure you are.”

“I’m thinking about visiting tomorrow,” she said reluctantly, ending it with an awkward laugh.

“Amazing! Oh Adora, that's amazing to hear. I have to wash your sheets and make your bed and—”

“Mom, mom it’s okay. Don’t stress,” she held the phone with her shoulder and her ear as she began to stuff a few things into her duffel bag. She had a few things she left at home so she didn’t need too much.

“How long will you stay home?”

“I’m not too sure yet…” *the shorter the better* . Maybe just after New Years, maybe even Christmas which was a few weeks away.

“I’ll tell your dad, okay? He’ll be excited!”

I have never seen him excited a day in his life. "Sure mom. Talk to you soon.

"Goodnight honey,"

"Goodnight."

She groaned into her hands. *This was going to be a long holiday.*

It was about a four hour drive back home. And it wasn't even a bad drive. The weather was surprisingly nice and the snow had almost all melted away. Super wide and empty roads, even though it was midday. Even though the drive was predominantly jumping from freeway to freeway, there were barely any cars. Partially because Adora was a bit too early for the Christmas-rush, and partially because no one really drove out here.

Her town never had people going in and out. The town itself had nothing. They had like one mall with a few shops and that's about it. The residents could barely keep themselves entertained; as if people would trek it out to see an overwhelming amount of nothing. Also no one ever left. It's one of those creepy incest towns where generations after generations of people stay in the exact same place. Virtually all her friends' parents met at the very high school they went to, so did their grandparents, so did their great-grandparents and so on. So most of them couldn't name a single suburb outside of the district.

That's why it was such a big deal that Adora left. People who leave were basically ostracised from the entire community. Treated as traitors who abandoned their loyalty to their weird cult.
God. She dreaded what was going to happen next.

Adora cruised along the familiar roads in her hand-me-down red Honda Accord. Her Spotify playlist, painfully titled "Sapphic Angst", blasted inside to try and prepare herself mentally. Only Hayley Kiyoko could save her now. She made a mental note of exactly what she needed to do:

- Be sweet and polite. Very sweet and polite. Like teeth-rottingly sweet and polite.

- Have good table manners. Her mom hated elbows on tables. Adora admittedly lived primarily off of two minute noodles and microwaved meals. Sometimes she had ice cream for breakfast. She would need to lie about that all.

- Don't talk about the degree. Her mom was horrified to learn that her only daughter would move 4 hours away. She was then even more horrified to learn that Adora was going to study something as "useless" and "boring" as Ancient History and Latin.

- Care about appearances. That's all her mom ever cared about. Her hair, her clothes, her smile. What other people will see—that's top priority. Always.

As the tall road-safety barriers became shorter and shorter, Adora swerved a gentle left off the freeway and began a gentle cruise down the residential streets. It was pure suburban around here. Similar-looking, painted homes up and down the road—all with a front porch, flowery yard and white-picket fences. Originality didn't exist around here.

What sucked most of all was how familiar it all was. The mall that she drove past was the same one that her friends went to every weekend—the one where they bought friendship necklaces in 7th grade; where she bowled for her 16th birthday party; where she got her driver's licence.

And that local cafe which had the best milkshakes, perfect for the hot summer day after high school. Her and her friends used to go every Friday during the summer, straight after track and field practice. The shopkeepers were her dad's former classmates. Pretty sure that the son took over the business; Brian M who she played in the band with.

It was bittersweet.

She turned that all-too-familiar street. The one she grew up on. Where she learnt to ride her bike. Where she ran in the dead of night after sneaking out to a party. And the same one she drove off of the day she graduated, promising to never look back.

But now she was back. *Oh fuck*. She was back.

Adora pulled into the driveway, parking directly behind her mom's SUV. Grabbing her backpack from the driver's seat and her keys, she dashed up the front steps and stood by the door. Her feet were perpendicular to the front door. *Okay, okay breathe*.

Please don't panic. Don't panic.

It's one Christmas holiday. It's a few weeks until Christmas, and then she can leave straight after. Don't look back this time. This one's final. She only came back this time because it was her first holiday away and her parents were entitled to at least one last family holiday. Even if they didn't know it yet.

So all Adora had to do was—

Suddenly, the door swung open, revealing her mom's wide smile. "Welcome home honey."

A tight squeeze. So tight.

"Hi mom…"

Her mom gave a quick look from head to toe. Then her expression stiffened. "You look bigger darling."

Yeah I've been lifting weights. She took a deep inhale and stretched a wider smile. "Sorry..."

"It doesn't matter now. It's cold honey, come in, come in."

She was ushered inside and was met with the home that she grew up. And creepily, nothing had changed. Like at all. Her graduation cap that she chucked on the table was still there, collecting dust a year later. They didn't even move it. Why didn't they move it?

"You came home just in time Adora," her mom gushed, taking the backpack from her and trying to push her towards the dining room. "I'm whipping up dinner right now and I just realised that I forgot to buy soda water from the shops. Could you go for me?"

Adora groaned. Her shoulders and legs were sore from the drive. But you know what, it's better than staying at home. "Of course mom. I'll just walk down."

"It's cold honey, you should just drive,"

"No, no I need to stretch my legs and get some fresh air. I'll just get a coat from my room."

My room. It wasn't even her room. She hadn't been there for a year, how could she call it her room? She ran up the stairs, took a sharp right and entered the room that was still adorned with her

name in bright, glittery letters. Adora had put it up when she was eight years old and had never taken it down. When she opened the door, she was met with pure nostalgia. Other than her neatly made bed, everything else had stayed the same. Her desk still had old nail polish and dusty makeup brushes. Her desk chair was still spun around towards her small tv. Her closet doors were wide open.

A quick sigh. That was not a can of worms she was bothered to open right now.

She grabbed the first coat she could see. It used to be her favourite. A muted grey, long coat with large double buttons. It used to be oversized and now seemed to fit her like a glove.

It was weird how things changed. How she changed. Juxtaposed with how everything here stayed the same. Adora wasn't sure how this was going to go—she just wanted things to go okay. But let's be honest, nothing ever goes okay here.

Chapter 2

Adora thanked the lord that her coat was as warm as she remembered. Because it was so cold that she could see her breath and not feel her fingertips. With her old house keys in her left pocket and some quick cash in her right, she made her way down the wide, unlined roads to the local corner store.

The bell chimed as she pushed her way in to the familiar shop. The nostalgic scent of cooked sausages lingered in the air.

"Adora!" a bright voice called for her.

"Kyle?" the slender boy stood by the cash register, his blond hair peeking just above the fully-stocked shelves. "I didn't know you worked here."

"Yeah, well Lonnie's parents hired me earlier this year and I've been saving up some cash for a new car so," he said excitedly. "What brings you to town? I haven't seen you since graduation."

"Well, it's the holidays so…" Adora grabbed a couple of bottles of soda water on her way to the counter. "I'm back from college."

She saw firsthand how his face contorted with the word 'college'. It was a mix of light disgust then an overwash of politeness.

“Have you seen anyone since you’ve been back?” he scanned the two items for her and popped them into a paper bag.

“I actually just arrived 10 minutes ago. So nope,” she handed over the cash. $2.30 exactly.

Kyle laughed, “I’m surprised you haven’t seen Catra yet.”

Catra. Catra. Catra.

The name repeated itself in her mind. Over and over. Her chest tightened, and she couldn’t help but to release a small gasp. Her best friend. Closest person in the world.

She hadn't spoken to her in a year. It was mostly because Catra literally didn’t have a phone. Adora wasn’t even sure if Catra ever got a phone. And they weren’t exactly going to be writing each other letters in this modern age.

They were supposed to do everything together, and maybe there was a part of her that was actively avoiding Catra because she felt guilty for leaving. She couldn’t bear to look her in the face.

But it had been a year and she already fucked up enough. The least she could do was reach out in person.

“She works in that 1950s-style diner across the road now by the way,” Kyle chimed. Adora snapped back into reality. “She started a few months ago. I saw her on a lunch break once.”

“Oh thanks, I’ll actually head over now,” she took the bag into her hands. “It was nice to see you.”

She ran across the road towards the diner. It was *the* diner in the area. And probably the most interesting thing in the town. It was a cute 1950s theme with black and white chequered floors, bright pink seats and plush seats. They also had the best food there — her go-to as a kid was always the cheese burger because they served the crispiest chips.

A bright blue poster with “KARAOKE FRIDAYS” was plastered on the front door. That hadn't changed it for as long as she’d been alive. The memories flooded back to her—when she was just a kid, her and Catra threw themselves on stage with little hesitation. They had mustered up the courage to sing a dumb little Disney song at the top of their lungs until their voices gave out. *Those were the days*. As Adora opened the door, she was met with a warm aroma of rich coffee.

“Welcome to—”

There she was.

When Adora met Catra in the eyes, there was a flash of time and space between them. The Catra from when they first met; at the local park as toddlers when they could barely walk. The Catra that was her desk-neighbour every single year growing up. The Catra that partnered with her for the science fair when they blew up a volcano by accident. The Catra that wore matching dresses to their Annual Ball; the same one that hated the music, and escaped with her to the school football field to watch the stars. And the Catra that cried in her arms after revealing she'd leave. And the same one that begged her not to go. Hopefully it was the same Catra that would forgive her.

"H-Hey," that's all Adora could say.

Catra stared. Adora felt like she was looking straight into her soul. To every inch of her muscles, veins and tissue. It was like a ghost was standing right in front of her.

"W-What…? You're…?" she inhaled. There was a pause between them. Adora mentally begged Catra to come up with something friendly. Maybe a hug. Maybe an 'I missed you'. But also she knew Catra well enough to know that none of those things could possibly happen. When the moment that felt like eternity lifted, Catra's face remained blank. "You can take a seat wherever you like."

Adora's heart faltered. She deserved that. She didn't deserve any form of real communication. She knew that. But it didn't hurt any less. She took the nearest booth since the place was pretty much empty.

“Do you need any drinks to start? Catra shoved the menu in front of her, trying to dodge her stare.

“Catra, I—”

“Can you just choose something?”

Adora stopped. She mentally fought for a second as to whether she should really keep pushing or whether she should give up. But then she mustered up the courage. “I-I hope you’ve been well.”

Okay, so she mustered up the courage but she wasn’t great at actually articulating herself. She wanted to apologise. She wanted to scream. She wanted to drag Catra with her to college. She wanted to hug her and never let her go.

“You wouldn’t know because you haven’t been here,” she spat, glancing straight down at her notepad. “Why are you even back?”

“Well it’s Christmas,”

Catra scoffed in disbelief. “As if you came back to see your parents.”

“I wanted to see you actually,” that’s when Catra looked up for a moment, though she quickly shut it down.

“You’re being stupid,” she dismissed Adora's comment completely. “You didn’t even tell me.”

“You don’t have a phone! Also—”

Catra shoved her hand in her pocket and slammed her cracked and out-of-date iPhone on the table. “There. Add me.”

Adora reluctantly turned on the phone to find a picture of them together as her lockscreen. It was an old one. The two of them when they were 11 years old at the local track and field competition . You could tell from their sports jersey and shorts. It was their favourite after-school activity at the time (until the coach skipped town for adultery but that was a story for another day). And every afternoon after a competition, they'd go to the local corner store and get a frozen raspberry shake. She missed those days. “Oh…”

Catra quickly snatched the phone back and entered the passcode. Her face burned with embarrassment, so much that she had to hide behind her hand. “I just didn’t have any other photo....”

“I really like that photo,” she tried to smile. When Catra handed back her phone, she began adding her phone number in. “Track and field comp. 5th Grade. The slushie that day was awful.”

“Well the ice was so chunky. It felt like chewing on rocks.”

They shared a bit of a chuckle.

But when it dwindled down, they found themselves in the same position they started. Adora awkward and Catra confused.

“Anyways I need to work so,” she took her phone back.

“I’ll wait,” she didn’t realise what she had said until it left her lips.

Catra stared at her in confusion. “I end in an hour.”

“Well I’ll wait an hour,” she sat back and pulled out her phone, a smug smirk across her lips, “I don’t have anything better to do.”

She snickered. “Then why are you walking around with two giant bottles of soda water?”

Oh shit . Adora completely forgot. *Nah fuck it* . “Nevermind that. I’ll stay for an hour.”

Catra seemed to be amused. “Well you better order something if you’re going to hog a booth to yourself for an hour.”

Adora finally cracked a real smile. “Coke and a cheeseburger please.”

“I should’ve seen that coming.”

6:08PM. That’s when they left. Slight overtime on Catra’s part but Adora couldn’t care less. And not just because she got a free refill on her coke.

Catra swung her handbag over her shoulder, grabbing her jacket which was spilling from the top. She had an amused smile across her lips.

“I can’t believe you actually waited,” Catra snickered. “Your mom’s gonna be pissed. That’s who the soda water’s for, right? Unless you turned into a middle aged woman since I last saw you.”

Adora scoffed. “Excuse you, I’ve always been a middle aged woman at heart. I thought you knew that about me,” she actually smiled. *Thank God* . “...I’m actually really glad I got to see you by the way. I only just arrived like 20 minutes before I saw you.”

Her smile slowly disappeared from her lips. “Oh yeah?”

“I mean, what’s everything been like over here? Have you met up with anyone from high school?”

“...not really,” Catra shoved her hands into her pockets. “I’ve been busy working. Like seriously busy. I mean, I saved up for like 6 months just to afford my crappy phone. And now I’m basically back down to zero so…” she breathed heavily. “Life sucks.”

“Catra I—”

“I’m sure your life is good, fun and exciting though,” she rolled her eyes. “Exciting campus, new friends. I bet you joined a bunch of new clubs or societies or whatever.”

Well just fencing, track and field, soccer but only during winter, Arts soc . “I guess I’ve been busy…”

“Typical Adora. Always booking herself up with too many activities. Though you seem to have a lot of time for playing pool nowadays,”

“I mean—” she paused. “Wait. How did you know about that?”

“What?”

“Me playing pool,”

Catra’s face dropped. “Y-You mentioned it.”

“No I didn’t,” Adora turned her entire body around to face her. “You only would’ve known if…" she shook her head. "Catra, do you know my Insta?”

She groaned. “Shut up. What if I do?”

“Then I’d be fucking pissed,”

“Woah Adora, language,” she joked.

“I’m being serious. Why didn’t you tell me? We could’ve added each other. I could’ve contacted you!” Adora couldn’t help but to shove Catra's shoulder. “What the hell?”

“It’s not that deep Adora,” she waved her hands about all-too-casually.

“Yes it is,” Adora stepped in front of her to stop her. Catra gave a sarcastically surprised expression. “Did you not want to talk to me or something?”

Catra sneered, “I didn’t think you’d take it so personally. I mean relax.”

“Stop being like this. I hate when you do this,” she shoved her again.

“Do what?”

“When you avoid talking about the issue,”

“Wow, Adora Gray talking about avoiding issues. How ironic.”

They stood at a stand still for a moment. Adora stared at her with a mixture of anger and hurt. Catra wasn’t…wrong. Not technically anyway. But it didn’t make it hurt any less. *God* . Especially because she was clearly just deflecting from the main point.

“God, why are you doing this? Just tell me why you didn't add me!”

Catra gave a quick huff. For a moment she thought over her own words, kind of realising her own flaws in the process. She eventually settled for a resolution.

"Because I saw your new friends okay?" Catra grumbled under her breath.

"What?"

"...I saw how happy you were with them and I couldn't say anything,"

"You were…" Adora just looked at her with disbelief in her eyes. "...jealous?"

"Psh, no," Catra aggressively denied, snaking past Adora's stance and returning to their route home. "It's already dark and we need to get home."

Adora brightened. "You were!"

"Shut up,"

"Catra's *jealous* ," she elbowed jokingly. "Ha, who knew."

Seeing Adora's toothy grin made Catra soften a little. Well, soften enough to give a sheepish smile at least. "Shut up. If it was the other way around, you would be jealous too."

She took note of that small grin and fed into it. " *Maybe* . There's no one cooler than me though."

"I can name a few. Lonnie. Entrapta. Maybe even Scorpia,"

"Okay, okay," Adora interrupted. "You think I'm a loser. Not like you're any better though. Remember when you laughed so hard you blew milk out your nose."

"Shut up. That was like 8 years ago,"

"Doesn't make it any less funny!"

They walked in comfortable silence for a few moments, the cool evening air wrapping around them. It felt almost like old times, but with a new, unspoken understanding hanging in the air.

"Hey," Adora said softly, breaking the silence. "I missed you, you know. A lot."

Catra looked at her, her eyes softening. “Yeah, I missed you too, Adora.”

As they continued walking, the distance that had grown between them over the past year seemed to shrink with each step, bringing them closer to finding their way back to each other.

Chapter 3

Adora sat at a local café, the aroma of freshly brewed coffee mingling with the crisp winter air. Despite the season, the day was surprisingly warm, allowing her to sit outside on a chair by herself. She needed to be alone at this point. She felt like she was suffocating at home.

The coffee was a bit stronger than she liked, but he loved to sip at it and watch the last leaves falling from the trees.

She plopped down the mug next to her ipad which was currently filled with Bow's frown and Glimmer's wide-mouthed laugh.

"What I'm saying is that roads are so much worse during Christmas. All the worst drivers are out," Glimmer complained, kicking her shoes off and plopping onto her bed. "We just went Christmas shopping and the roads were a nightmare."

"Glimmer you *are* the dangerous driver," Adora joked,

"No, no I'm so much better at home I swear. Frosta's in the car with me and I can't kill her,"

"What a loving sister," she snorted.

"What? No, she's annoying. But I don't wanna end up in jail!"

Adora chuckled. She hadn't met Frosta before but she's overheard her during phone calls and she seemed so cute. Though she'd never understand what it was like to have a sibling. She dismissed it, noticing Bow's head buried in his hands. "You okay?"

"I should've never taken this unit!" he screamed. Bow was still in his dorm, surrounded by textbooks and notes. "I can't wait to finally be done. My dads promised their signature apple pie this weekend and I need it desperately."

"They do make the best pie," Glimmer reminisced.

"That sounds so good. I would do anything to eat anything but mushy peas," Adora fake cried, though to be honest, she actually really did want to cry. She was sick of mashed potato and bland chicken.

When she took another sip of her coffee, she spotted Cotta walking in her work uniform—a pink flair skirt, a messily done apron with a white polo—walking alongside Scorpia who she admittedly hadn't seen in almost a full year (she almost couldn't recognise her from her severely chopped hair).

"Hey guys, gotta go," Adora said with half a mind.

“Wait what—”

She shut the ipad and shoved it in her bag, sculling the rest of her coffee and dashing over to them.

“Catra! Scorpia!” she called out, waving awkwardly. Only now realising that she actually had no plan for this conversation.

Catra turned, her eyes widening in surprise. “Adora?”

God she looked cute in her uniform . Adora stretched an awkward smile. “Hey, I just wanted to say hi. I saw you guys and… yeah.”

Scorpia beamed, her enthusiasm palpable. “Hey, Adora! That’s so nice of you to come over. We should all hang out!”

Adora glanced at Catra with keanness but the latter just rolled her eyes. “Yeah, sure whatever.”

That was enough of a win for Adora. “That sounds great. What are you guys up to?”

“We’re just on break right now,” Catra said, her tone neutral. “We were going to grab something to eat.”

Scorpia's eyes lit up with excitement. “There’s this new place that serves the best loaded fries with all kinds of toppings. You have to try them! They have everything from cheese and bacon to guacamole and jalapeños. And the portions are huge! I've been there like three times already this week. Oh, and they also have these amazing—”

Catra cut her off, a small smile playing on her lips. “Scorpia, we get it. You’re hungry. Let’s just go.”

They walked together to the restaurant down the street. The sign above the door read "Dardo’s Sandwich Shack." As they entered, the smell of freshly baked bread, sizzling bacon, and melted cheese greeted them. The place wasn’t fancy, but it had a cosy, welcoming vibe with chequered tablecloths and old photos on the walls.

They found a booth near the window and sat down. The menus were laminated and a bit worn from use, but that just added to the charm.

“So, Adora,” Scorpia began, leaning forward eagerly. “How’s college?”

Adora smiled, grateful for the distraction. “It’s been good. Busy, but good. Lots of studying, societies, and all that. But I’ve made some great friends and learned a lot. What about you?”

Scorpia nodded enthusiastically. “That sounds awesome. I’ve been working a lot, at the same place as Catra. Line cook. It’s actually great because I get free food all the time. Though it’s also a lot of chips.”

The waiter came over, a friendly young man with a notepad. Pretty sure that was Rogelio’s older brother. Similar, angular jawline and built like a typical footballer. “Hi there, what can I get for you?”

Adora glanced at the menu. “I’ll have the turkey club sandwich with a side of sweet potato fries, please.”

Catra barely glanced at her menu. “BLT for me. And regular fries.”

Scorpia grinned. “I’ll take the loaded fries with bacon and cheese. Oh, and a root beer.”

The waiter jotted down their orders and left them to their conversation.

“So, Adora,” Scorpia said, her eyes sparkling with curiosity. “What’s dorm life like? Is it true that there are always these crazy parties happening all the time?”

Adora laughed. “Well, there are parties, but it’s not like the movies. My dorm is pretty quiet most of the time, to be honest. The ones on West Campus get crazy though.”

Scorpia quickly received her root beer and took a quick swing at it. “Really?”

“Oh yeah. Like, people passed out on the ground and campus security had to come. It was crazy. But we’re so chill in my building. We have study groups and movie nights. And sometimes we all just hang out in the common room and talk. The common room on my floor is so cool,”

“Sounds pretty nice,” she took another gulp. “What’s a common room?”

“Oh, it’s like spaces and rooms where anyone in the building can come and hang out. For ours there’s like a huge TV, colourful sofas and a few desks and chairs to study. There’s these huge windows to see outside. God, it’s the best,” Adora gushed.

“That sounds amazing!”

Catra shrugged, her tone indifferent. “Yeah, I guess that’s okay.”

Scorpia turned to Catra, genuine confusion on her face. “That’s unlike you Catra. You gush about Adora all the time.”

Catra's eyes widened in shock and embarrassment, her cheeks turning a deep shade of red. She opened her mouth to respond but found herself at a loss for words, mortified by Scorpia's revelation. She spurted through a rolex of randomised words, before just shutting her lips.

Adora's eyes lit up with excitement, though she tried to play it cool. "You do?"

Scorpia nodded enthusiastically, oblivious to Catra's distress. "Oh, yeah! She never shuts up about you. *'Adora did this, Adora did that, did you know Adora won last week's game'* ," she mimicked lightheartedly. "It's all she talks about at work."

Catra glared at Scorpia, her voice a harsh whisper. "Dude, shut the fuck up."

"No way," Adora's smile somehow stretched even wider. "Who knew? Catra's actually kind of nice."

"Catra's surprisingly sweet, you know?" right on cue the waiter came back with their orders, placing it in front of them respectively. "Oh you should've seen her when we ran into those kittens the other day. Oh my gosh, her face was like—"

“Okay that’s enough Scorpia,” Catra shoved a whole sandwich in her mouth, dying of embarrassment.

“No, I wanna hear about it,” Adora chuckled.

“I took pictures,”

Adora brightened as bright as the sun. “Really?!”

“Stop it Scorpia,”

She whipped out the phone, completely ignoring her. “Okay here’s my favourite.”

Catra groaned into her hands with complete and utter embarrassment which she honestly couldn’t describe. Though there was a part of her, deep in her chest, that couldn't get enough of it. Maybe she was a slut for pain, who knows?

Chapter 4

The old wooden pews creaked under the weight of the congregation, the familiar smell of polished wood and burning candles filling the air. Adora shifted uncomfortably in her seat, trying to ignore the droning voice of the pastor at the front of the church.

Her parents sat beside her, her mother with her hands folded neatly in her lap, her father staring intently at the sermon as if he could absorb the words by sheer willpower. Adora fidgeted with the hem of her sweater, her eyes darting around the familiar surroundings. She hadn't set foot in this church for over a year, and it felt both comfortingly familiar and stiflingly alien. Her mother's hand reached out to still her restless fingers, a silent command to sit still and behave.

Across the aisle, Catra sat with her mother, her expression one of detached boredom. Adora's mind began to wander, the words of the pastor fading into the background. Back in the day, Adora and Catra would run through the fields behind the church after Sunday school, laughing and playing tag until they were called back for the final hymn. She remembered the warmth of those days. Sure they hated Sunday school (and would learn to hate it more and more as the years went on), but the time she spent with Catra was special. In an indescribable sort of way.

The final hymn began to play, signalling the end of the service. The congregation stood, and Adora joined them reluctantly. She could feel the tension in her shoulders ease as the last notes of the hymn echoed through the church, and the pastor gave the closing blessing.

As they filed out of the church, Adora breathed a sigh of relief, the cold winter air hitting her face like a refreshing splash of water. She pulled her coat tighter around her, feeling the chill seep through the fabric. The sky was a dull grey, thick clouds promising snow. The trees were bare, their skeletal branches stretching toward the heavens, and the ground was dusted with a light layer of frost.

Catra and her mother lingered near the steps, and Adora made her way over to them, her parents trailing behind.

"Hey," she called out, catching Catra's eye. "Glad that's over."

Catra laughed, her breath visible in the cold air. "You and me both. I thought I was going to fall asleep in there."

“Tell me about it. It was rough,” Adora muttered, rubbing her hands together for warmth.

Catra nodded, pulling her scarf tighter around her neck. “I’m surprised you didn’t burst into flames the second you walked in.”

Adora laughed, the sound mingling with the crunch of snow beneath their feet. “I almost did. This place just... I don’t belong here anymore, you know?”

Catra's eyes softened, her usual guarded expression fading. "Yeah, I get it…"

The sky above them was a pale gray, heavy with the promise of more snow. The air was sharp and clean, every breath a reminder of the season's chill.

"It's actually so cold today. I feel like we can whip out our iconic snowball fights soon," Adora joked.

That made Catra smirk even wider. "Yeah, I always win at those so let's go."

Before they could continue, Adora's mom came rushing towards them. Her overly sweet voice entered, "Oh Catra. You don't ever change, do you sweetheart?" she caught her breath. "How have things been for you and your mother lately? It's been a while."

Catra's mother glanced at her daughter before speaking with a low tone. "We're managing, thank you."

They weren't managing. Everyone in that conversation knew. And yet Adora's mom kept pushing.

"Managing, you say? Well, it's good to hear you're getting by," she said with a smile that didn't reach her eyes. "You know, Catra, I

always admired how resourceful you are. It’s such a... valuable trait in these times.”

Catra shifted uncomfortably, her jaw clenching slightly. “Thanks, Mrs. Grey.”

Adora bristled at her mother’s condescending tone but held her tongue. She could see Catra’s discomfort and wanted to intervene, but she knew it would only make things worse.

Adora’s mom continued, her voice syrupy sweet. “Why don’t you and your mother come over for tea? It’s so cold out here, and it would be nice to catch up properly.”

Catra’s mother hesitated, glancing at Catra for her input. Catra looked like she wanted to be anywhere but there, but she nodded slightly. “Sure. Why not?”

Adora’s mom beamed, though her eyes betrayed a hint of irritation. “Wonderful! We’ll see you at our place in a few minutes then.”

As she walked away, Adora let out a breath she hadn’t realised she was holding. She turned to Catra, giving her an apologetic look. “I’m sorry about that.”

Catra shrugged, trying to brush it off. “It’s fine. I can handle it.”

The drive home was silent, the tension in the car palpable. Adora glanced at Catra, who was staring out the window, her expression unreadable. Her mother kept up a steady stream of chatter with Catra's mother, but it was clear that neither of them were really listening.

When they arrived at the Gray household, Adora's mom quickly ushered them inside, the warmth of the house a stark contrast to the cold outside. The living room was immaculate, decorated tastefully for the holidays with a large Christmas tree in the corner, its lights twinkling merrily.

"Please, make yourselves comfortable," Adora's mom said, gesturing to the plush couches. "I'll just put on the kettle."

Adora sat next to Catra on the couch, feeling the awkwardness settle in. Her father retreated to his study, leaving the women to their strained socialising. Adora could see her mother bustling around the kitchen, preparing tea and arranging a tray of cookies with precise care.

Catra's mother, trying to maintain a semblance of politeness despite her usually stoic and silent nature, asked, "So Adora…" she clasped her hands on top of her lap. "I heard you've been at college. How is that treating you?"

Adora forced a smile. "It's good. Busy, but good."

Catra snorted softly, earning a glare from Adora's mother as she re-entered the room with the tea tray. "Well, isn't that nice," she said, setting the tray down on the coffee table. "And what about you, Catra? Any plans for the future?"

Catra's eyes flicked to Adora before she answered. "I'm just trying to figure things out. Working a lot, saving up."

"Well, I think it's great that you stayed home," Adora's mom said, handing out cups of tea. "Looking after your mother, staying local. I think that's very admirable."

Adora groaned into her cup of piping hot tea. "Mom…"

"What, dear?" her mother said innocently, taking a seat and smoothing her skirt. "I just think it's important to highlight how responsible Catra is being."

Catra's expression hardened, but she kept her tone neutral. "It's not like I had much of a choice."

Catra's mom gave her daughter a pointed look. "Catra's been very helpful around the house. We manage as best we can. We don't have everything but—"

“We’re fine,” Catra finished for her.

They sat in an awkward silence for a moment. Adora drew up out a long sip of tea, feeling the liquid burn the insides of her throat.

"Wait," she suddenly spoke up. "What do you mean? Is everything okay?"

Catra and her mom looked at each other for a second.

“Hmm, I thought your mother would’ve told you,” Catra’s mom said with a faint, bitter smile. “I’ve confided in her a few times. How Catra’s had to pick up the slack.”

Adora’s eyes darted to her mother, who was suddenly very interested in stirring her tea. “No, she didn’t mention that.”

“Well, it’s not something we like to broadcast,” her mother said, her voice tight. “We all have our struggles. Catra’s been very brave, hasn’t she?”

Catra’s jaw clenched, and she stared at her tea. “Yeah. Brave.”

Adora’s mind whirled, piecing together the fragments. Everything seemed messy and yet so self-explanatory at the same time. Her

mother had never mentioned their financial situation in their calls or texts. Because she could've done something. Right?

Adora’s mom chimed in, her voice overly cheerful. “Well, let’s not dwell on the past. We’re all here now, and that’s what matters. How about we enjoy our tea?”

They sat in an uncomfortable silence, sipping their tea and nibbling on cookies. Adora kept glancing at Catra, but Catra avoided her gaze, staring intently at her cup. The minutes dragged on, and the tension in the room was palpable.

Finally, the tea was finished, and Catra’s mom began to gather her things. Adora’s mom stood up with a bright, forced smile. “Thank you for coming. It was lovely to catch up.”

“Thank you for having us.”

As they moved towards the door, Adora spoke up. “Catra and I can handle the dishes. Right, Catra?”

Catra’s eyes flicked to her mother, who gave a small nod. “Sure. We’ll clean up.”

Adora’s mom looked surprised but didn’t argue. “All right. Thank you, girls.”

As the adults left the room, Adora and Catra gathered the cups and saucers, carrying them to the kitchen in silence. Once they were out of earshot, Adora turned to Catra, her voice soft. “Catra, I’m really sorry. I didn’t even think that—”

Catra cut her off, her voice sharp. “But you didn’t know, did you? So it doesn’t matter.”

Adora flinched at the bitterness in Catra’s tone. “I didn’t mean to leave you alone. I thought you were okay. I thought you were just… doing your own thing.”

“Doing my own thing?” Catra scoffed, slamming a cup down on the counter. “I’ve been taking care of my mom, working nonstop, trying to keep everything from falling apart. And you were off making new friends, joining clubs, living your perfect little college life.”

Adora stepped back, hurt flashing across her face. “That’s not fair, Catra. You know it’s not like that.”

Catra rounded on her, her eyes blazing. “Isn’t it? You left. You didn’t look back. You didn’t even think to check in on me. I’ve been struggling, and you were just… gone.”

Adora felt tears prick at her eyes, but she blinked them away. “I didn’t know. I thought… I thought….”

Catra’s expression softened for a moment, but then she shook her head. “You don’t get it, Adora. You’re supposed to be my best friend, and you just disappeared.”

“I’m sorry,” Adora whispered, her voice breaking.

Catra sighed, running a hand through her hair. “Just forget it okay? Let’s just get this shit over and done with. I have shit to do.”

They finished the dishes in silence, the unspoken words and unresolved feelings lingering between them. Adora had three billion things she wanted to say but she ultimately gulped it all down.

Chapter 5

Adora needed to get out of the house. *Desperately*.

The morning sun filtered through the thin curtains of her childhood bedroom. She had woken up early (she was a morning person after all), but she was further fuelled with a determination to make a head start on her semester two assessments. I mean, was this an excuse to get out of the house? Sure. Maybe. Okay probably. But also the workload was only going to get harder, and she knew she needed every advantage she could get.

But okay more than that, she needed a break from her parents.

The previous day had been exhausting. Her mom had insisted on a family outing to buy more Christmas decorations, despite their house already looking like a holiday display straight out of a magazine. They had spent hours in crowded stores, her mom nitpicking every ornament and her dad trying to steer the shopping cart with an air of strained patience.

The final straw had been a ridiculous argument about her coming home too late after meeting up with Catra.

So that morning, she grabbed her backpack and headed out. It was too early for her to get a complaint from her parents. But late enough to enjoy the morning sun.

The local library was small. Only one open area with a few desks, and a single meeting room which was barely ever used. But it was cosy. Tall bookshelves lining the walls, each filled with a mix of well-loved novels and scholarly texts. Soft, worn carpets muffled her footsteps as she walked towards the study area, where a few scattered tables were occupied by a handful of diligent students and the occasional elderly reader. The large windows let in plenty of natural light, creating a warm and inviting atmosphere despite the cold outside.

Adora chose a table near the back, dropping her bag onto the chair with a sigh of relief.

Her and Catra used to spend countless late nights here, cramming for exams and working on projects. Ones that she looked back and laughed at how easy they were compared to what she was doing now.

She remembered one night in particular when they had stayed until closing time, huddled together at a table just like this one. Catra had been struggling with maths, and Adora had patiently explained each problem, watching as the frustration melted from Catra's face and was replaced with understanding. They had laughed and joked, whispering conspiratorially as the librarian shot them disapproving glances.

She sighed, pushing the memory aside and focusing on the task at hand. Seriously. She had to focus on the task at hand. But as she opened her laptop and began to type, she couldn't help but to feel a pang of longing for those simpler times. When life's biggest worries were exams and school projects, and when she and Catra

had been inseparable. Things were...perfect. God, she wishes she understood how perfect she had it.

Adora was lost in her thoughts, fingers hovering over her keyboard, when she noticed a familiar figure at one of the library's few computers. For a moment, she thought she was dreaming. But when she saw the fresh piercings on her ear, she knew it was the present. *Catra*.

Catra was intently focused on the screen, typing away like she was running out of time. The computers were those old types with the big back, coupled with a chunky keyboard with the loudest clicks. Adora’s heart skipped a beat.

She gathered her courage and walked over. “Catra? What are you doing here?”

Catra looked up abruptly, eyes widening with surprise. She quickly tried to minimise the window on her computer. “Adora? What are you doing here?”

Adora chuckled nervously. “I mean technically I asked first," she tried to say jokingly but Catra was staring at her with literally zero upturn to her lips. "...I needed to get away from my parents actually. They're driving me insane. But you... you're studying?

Catra shifted uncomfortably, clearly not wanting to discuss what was on her screen. “As if no.”

“Catra, I know what your face looks like when you study,”

“What the hell is that supposed to mean?”

“You do like this,” she jokingly furrowed her brows together and drew out her mouth into a frown. “This face.”

“Do not,”

“Do to,”

Catra shot her a wary look, clearly still tense from their previous argument. “Not that you need to know but fine, I am studying.”

“For what?”

Catra hesitated, then glanced around to make sure no one was listening. “I'm studying remotely…”

“What?!”

The librarian shushed them.

Catra glanced at the screen, then back at Adora, before muttering, “Biology. I’m working on prerequisites so I can eventually start a veterinary course.”

Adora’s eyes lit up with excitement. “Catra, that’s amazing! Why are you keeping it a secret?”

Catra looked away, her voice barely above a whisper. “Because it’s stupid. It's a stupid dream. I’m just wasting my time.”

Adora stepped closer, her expression earnest. “No, it’s not. It’s incredible. You love animals. You’d make an amazing vet. Why would you think that’s stupid?”

Catra shrugged, her eyes filled with doubt. “Because... I don’t know. It just feels like chasing something that’s out of reach. My mom needs me, and there’s no time or money for this. I’m only doing this because it’s like a free course or whatever. It’s just to keep me busy…that’s all…”

Adora frowned, not buying Catra’s dismissive tone. “Why don’t you go to college in person? You could get scholarships, financial aid. There are ways to make it work.”

Catra’s expression hardened. “I'm not smart...I'm not you."

"Catra, I—"

"Plus I have my mom, Adora. You know that."

Adora sighed, frustration creeping into her voice. "But you need to live your own life. You're the kid, Catra. You deserve to do what you want."

Catra's eyes flashed with a mixture of anger and pain. "You don't get it, Adora. It's not that simple. I can't just leave her. She needs me."

Adora opened her mouth to argue but stopped herself, seeing the resolve in Catra's eyes. She felt a pang of helplessness, realising that maybe she really didn't understand the full weight of Catra's situation. She wanted to understand. She really did. But she felt a tinge of her own privilege coming to light and decided to back off.

"Fine," she said softly, stepping back. "I'm sorry. I just... I want you to be happy."

Catra looked away, her expression unreadable. "Yeah, well, sometimes you don't get to choose."

Feeling the tension thick in the air, Adora turned and left the library, her mind swirling with thoughts and emotions. She knew they had a lot to work through, but for now, it seemed like the distance between them was as vast as ever.

As Adora wandered through the quiet streets, her mind become a whirlwind of thoughts. Catra's words echoed in her head. Was Catra…right? She always knew that family was important, of course, she loved her parents in a weird, messed up way. But she never felt like living with them forever. But Catra did. Why?

It wasn't something she had fully grasped before, having been so absorbed in her own escape to college, where she could finally breathe freely and explore her own dreams.

The cold air was biting at her cheeks. What did it mean to be tied down by responsibilities? Was it fair to judge someone for staying behind when their loved ones needed them? Catra had always seemed so strong, so fiercely independent, yet here she was, bound by her sense of duty to her mom. Her only family. Adora couldn't help but feel a pang of guilt for not seeing it sooner.

If Adora was so understanding of Catra and her life, why did she want to hate her for staying? Why did she feel so adamant about taking her hand and running away with her to her college? Why couldn't she just be…happy for her? Was she a terrible person for wanting her to leave? Maybe. Probably. The more she thought about it, the more she started thinking it.

Obligations. Sacrifices. Dreams. Could you balance dreams with expectations? If so, at what cost?

And how was she thinking more about philosophy during her holidays than during her actual Arts philosophy unit she had to take first sem?

Adora reached her home around noon, her backpack slung over her shoulder. She didn't even end up studying after all of it. She just wandered and wondered for hours until she conveniently ended up at home. As she opened the front door, her mom's voice greeted her, tinged with irritation.

"Adora, where have you been?" her mom demanded, standing in the hallway with her arms crossed. "You didn't tell anyone where you were going. We were worried sick!"

Adora sighed, dropping her backpack by the door. "I went to the library. I needed to get some work done."

Eh. Half true.

"You should have told us," her mom snapped. "We had plans to finish decorating the house. You know how important this is to me, to us."

Adora felt a familiar knot of frustration tightening in her chest. “It was like three bloody hours mom. It’s like noon!”

“I don’t care Adora. It’s my house. My rules,”

“Mom, I’m not a child. I don’t need to report every single move I make,”

Her mom’s eyes narrowed. “That’s not the point, Adora. You have responsibilities here. You can’t just run off whenever you feel like it.”

“I have responsibilities to my college too mom,” Adora retorted, trying to keep her voice calm.

“Oh it’s always about your college and studies, isn’t it Adora? I wish you’d make practical choices darling. You can’t just float around, chasing dreams that won’t pay the bills,”

Adora clenched her fists, feeling the weight of her mother’s words bearing down on her. “This is exactly why I can’t stay here.”

Her mom’s face tightened, a flicker of pain crossing her eyes. “Adora, we just want what’s best for you. You need to understand that.”

“No, Mom,” Adora said, her voice breaking. “You want what’s best for you. You want me to fit into this mould that makes you comfortable. But I can’t do that. I can’t be that person.”

Oh shit . First of all, she had never screamed at her like that. Maybe arguments for sure, but screaming? Never. Second of all, Adora hadn't realised that she accidentally went on about “fitting in” and being “comfortable”. That had nothing to do with college. That had everything to do with—

No. We’re not talking about that. Not right now.

She grabbed her backpack and headed up the stairs, leaving her mom standing in the hallway. As she entered her room, she felt a mixture of relief and despair. This was why she couldn’t stay here. God. She wished that there was some way to explain that to Catra.

Adora sat on her bed, staring at the ceiling, and for the first time in a long while, she felt the heavy weight of her decisions. She knew that she had to find a way to balance her own desires with the reality of her family’s expectations, but at this moment, all she could feel was the overwhelming need to break free.

Chapter 6

Adora sat on her bed, staring at her phone. Her fingers hovered over the screen, hesitation gnawing at her. The words she had typed felt inadequate, and borderline stupid but she needed to reach out to her. With a deep breath, she hit send.

ADORA: I'm sorry about everything.

She stared at the screen, waiting for a response. Minutes ticked by with no reply. She felt like a crazy ex just wanting attention desperately. Maybe she was to some extent. Disappointment weighed heavily on her chest, but she understood. She had left things unresolved, and now it was up to her to make amends. But it didn't make the feeling any easier.

She groaned to herself. Unable to stay still, she decided to dash out her room and out to her backyard. What stood in front of her, all the way in the back corner of her fence, was their old treehouse. Not hers. Theirs.

Their dads had built it for them when they were kids after realising their backyards were adjacent. What were the odds right? Neighbourhood friends turned best friends had a shared backyard.

Man. This was a place filled with memories, and maybe, just maybe, it could be a place for reconciliation.

Adora and Catra were about seven years old, standing in awe as their dads hammered the final nails into their new treehouse. It was small but sturdy, nestled in the branches of the old oak tree that stood on the line between their properties.

"Go on, give it a try," Adora's dad had said, smiling broadly.

The two girls had scrambled up the ladder, their laughter echoing through the neighbourhood. Inside, the treehouse was cosy and simple, with just enough space for them to sit and play. They had spent countless hours there, whispering secrets and making plans, their bond growing stronger with each passing day.

Adora climbed up the familiar ladder, her fingers brushing against the rough wood. The treehouse was dusty, the air thick with the scent of aged timber. On the wooden wall was a tiny blackboard with two little stubs of chalk. '*Catra and Adora's House! Do not Disturb*' was messily written from when it was first made, and practically never touched again. They used to carry up blankets and pillow which were nowhere to be seen. She sighed to herself before peering out the small window on the other side. Her breath caught.

Catra was in her kitchen which faced her backyard, washing up at the sink. She looked like she was in the middle of washing up. The sight of her, so close yet so far, made Adora’s heart ache. She grabbed a few small sticks from the floor of the treehouse and, with a mischievous grin, started throwing them at Catra's window.

It took a few tries, but finally, Catra looked up, a perplexed expression on her face. She saw Adora in the treehouse and shook her head, clearly thinking, *What the hell?*

Adora waved, a hopeful smile on her face. Catra hesitated for a moment before slowly walking towards the treehouse. As she approached, Adora felt a mix of anxiety and anticipation. This was her chance to make things right.

Catra climbed up the ladder, her movements cautious. She stepped into the treehouse, glancing around at the dusty interior before looking at Adora.

"What are you doing?! You could've cracked a window!"

"It was just sticks! At least I didn't throw rocks,"

"This isn't 'Check yes Juliet' Adora!"

Adora took a deep breath. "I just wanted to get your attention, okay?"

Catra crossed her arms, leaning against the wall. "And you thought throwing sticks at my window was the best way to do that?"

Adora laughed softly. “It got your attention, didn’t it?”

Catra rolled her eyes, “And you think that knocking the fucking door wouldn’t?”

“I didn’t want to disturb your mom.”

They stood there in the treehouse, the silence stretching out between them. Adora felt the weight of her mistakes, but also the hope of making things right. This place, filled with so many happy memories, seemed like the perfect backdrop for a new beginning.

“I just…” she took a deep breath. “I wanted to make things up with you.”

“Well,” she shrugged. “What do you want to do then?”

Adora and Catra stood in the treehouse, the dust motes dancing in the shafts of sunlight that filtered through the small windows. The air was thick with the weight of their unspoken words and unresolved tension, but Adora was determined to bridge the gap between them.

“It's still the day,” Adora said, trying to keep her tone light and hopeful. “Why don’t we do something to catch up?”

Catra raised an eyebrow, clearly sceptical. “What are you on about?”

Adora grinned, the excitement bubbling up inside her. “Let’s get our bikes and go to that milkshake bar downtown. You remember it, right? The one we used to go to all the time?”

Catra's eyes flickered with recognition, but she still seemed hesitant. “I don’t know, Adora. It’s been a while.”

“Exactly!” Adora said, her enthusiasm unwavering. “Let’s go back and relive some of those good times. Come on, it’ll be fun.”

After a moment of hesitation, Catra sighed and gave a small nod. “Okay, fine. Let’s do it.”

They climbed down from the treehouse and headed to their respective garages. Adora’s old bike was a bit dusty, but it still worked. It was that sleek red colour she loved so much. The same one her dad used to pump up the wheels for every weekend. She hopped on, feeling a rush of nostalgia as her feet found the pedals.

Catra joined her moments later, and they started down the familiar streets of their neighbourhood—hers a golden orange colour. The sun was high in the sky, casting a warm glow over everything. The houses, the trees, the sidewalks—all of it felt like

a walk down memory lane. As they rode side by side, Adora couldn’t help but smile.

The rhythmic sound of their pedalling filled the air, mingling with the chirping of birds and the distant hum of lawnmowers. The breeze tugged at their hair and clothes, carrying with it the scents of freshly cut grass and blooming flowers. It was as if time had rewound, and they were kids again, carefree and full of life. Just little 9 year olds on the weekend, trying to get as much in before school started again on Monday.

“Remember when we used to race down this hill?” Adora called out, pointing to a steep incline ahead.

Catra laughed, her voice clear and bright. “Yeah, and you always cheated by starting early!”

“I did not!” Adora protested, but she couldn’t stop the laughter that bubbled up inside her.

They zoomed down the hill, the wind whipping past them, making them feel alive and free.

As they continued their journey, familiar landmarks came into view —the old park where they first met, the school where they shared countless memories, the bakery that always smelled of fresh bread and pastries.

Finally, they reached the local cafe downtown. Virtually right next to their high school, just a few stores down. They always had the best milkshakes. Almost sweet and so creamy.

They parked their bikes outside and walked in, the bell above the door jingling to announce their arrival. The smell of sweet milkshakes and fried food enveloped them.

They slid into one of the booths, and a waitress came over, smiling brightly. “What can I get for you girls today?”

Adora glanced down at the menu. *Yikes. $6 for a milkshake. Recession is hitting hard.*

“Two chocolate milkshakes, please. Extra whipped cream.”

Catra rolled her eyes but smiled. “You and your sweet tooth.”

They waited in comfortable silence, the old jukebox in the corner playing a soft tune. When their milkshakes arrived, they clinked their glasses together in a mock toast.

“To old times,” Adora said, grinning.

She slurped it down. They used to joke that the store snuck drugs into them because they just tasted *that* good. No other place did it like them. And Adora would never admit it, but she secretly tried to find some near campus and failed every time because nothing came close to it.

"So," Catra swirled the milkshake around with the straw, letting the whipped cream mix in. "Why are you doing this all of a sudden?"

Adora peered up, her straw still in her mouth. "I missed you."

"I missed you too…I guess,"

"And I don't want to waste more time,"

"Huh," Catra gave a sigh. "So you are still leaving though."

She avoided her gaze. "Well I have to."

"-And you're acting like there's this timer…so I'm guessing you're leaving real soon then,"

"I don't have a set date or anything," she pushed her milkshake aside to grab Catra's hand which was dangling on the side of the

table. Catra stared at her with wide eyes. “Look. Let’s not focus on that right now. Let’s just focus on the moment. The fact that we’re here, and we still have Christmas and New Years and so many things we need to catch up on. Isn’t that important? Isn’t that special?”

Catra gave her a long pause. Then pushed aside her milkshake to grab her hand back. “I guess you’re right.”

Adora stepped through the front door. The warmth of the house was a nice contrast to how freezing it was outside. She barely had time to take off her shoes before her mother’s voice echoed through the hallway.

“Adora, where have you been?”

Adora sighed, bracing herself for the confrontation. “I was just hanging out with Catra, mom.”

Her mother’s eyes narrowed, her arms crossed over her chest. “And what about me, Adora? Your own mother?”

Adora felt a pang of guilt but pushed it aside. “Mom, I’ve spent plenty of time with you. There’s still time for us to hang out before I leave.”

Her mother’s expression softened slightly, but the tension remained. “I always get the feeling you choose Catra over spending time with us, Adora.”

“That’s not true,” Adora said, her frustration bubbling to the surface.

They stood there, staring at each other, the air thick with unspoken words.

“You’ve been off ever since you've been back,” her mother finally said, her voice strained. “We fought before, and you didn’t even try to make it up to me.”

“What did I have to apologise for?” Adora shot back. “I didn’t do anything wrong.”

“Of course, Adora. You’re perfect now, aren’t you?” Her mother’s voice dripped with sarcasm. “What happened to you? You never fought back to me like this. Never.”

“College happened,” she replied.

“You’ve changed, Adora. You act like you’re above us now. Like we’re just a part of your past,”

Adora clenched her fists, trying to keep her anger in check. "That's not fair. I'm trying to balance everything. College, my friends, my family."

"We should always come first," her mother snapped. "It feels like you're slipping away, like we don't matter to you anymore."

Adora's heart pounded in her chest. "That's not true. I'm here, aren't I? I'm trying."

Her mother shook her head, her eyes filled with sadness. "I just want my daughter back. The one who used to care about this family."

Adora felt a lump form in her throat. "I'm still here, Mom."

They stood there in silence, the distance between them feeling greater than ever. Adora wanted to bridge that gap, to make her mother understand, but the words wouldn't come. She turned and headed to her room, her mind swirling with a mix of anger and regret.

As she closed the door behind her, she couldn't shake the feeling that no matter how hard she tried, she would always be torn between the different parts of her life. And as much as she

wanted to make everyone happy, she realised that it might never be enough.

Chapter 7

Adora laid in bed, staring at the ceiling, the chill of the night seeping through her thin blankets. Sleep was impossible. Look, she wasn't a stranger to not sleeping (college does that to you), but this felt different. It actually made her miss stressing over essays and upcoming presentations because it felt way worse to contemplate her literal family structure.

The argument with her mom replayed in her head. Each word was a sharp reminder of how suffocated she was here. Everything here was as awful as she thought it was going to be. Well except Catra. She groaned, pulling the blankets up to her chin. The cold only made it worse, biting at her skin and keeping her awake.

She turned over, pulling the blankets tighter around her, but it was no use. The restlessness in her chest grew until she couldn’t stand it anymore. She needed to move, to escape. Without another thought, she threw everything off of her, grabbed her keys from the nightstand, and slipped on her shoes.

Adora crept down the stairs, careful not to make a sound. The house was eerily silent. She paused for a moment at the front door, taking a deep breath, before stepping out into the cold night. The frigid air wrapped around her.

She got into her car, the engine roaring to life, and she drove. She didn’t have a destination in mind, just a need to be anywhere but here. It felt like she was sleepwalking; letting all the muscle memory do the work. When she stopped, she found herself on the

other side of the block. The very house that sat perfectly on the other side of her house. Catra's.

Parking a little down the street, she sat in the car for a moment, staring at Catra's house. It was quiet, the windows dark. She pulled out her phone.

ADORA: Hey I'm outside.

ADORA: wanna come out?

There was a long pause. Catra might've been at work. Maybe she was asleep. Maybe this whole thing was stupid and she shouldn't have come. But then her phone buzzed with a reply.

CATRA: what

She saw the top bedroom window flash awake, the blinding yellowy light making Adora snap. She saw her head peer up from the windowpane, her wild, untangled locks visible in her silhouette.

Adora hesitated for a moment, then continued typing.

ADORA: come on

The light flicked to black again. For a moment, her chest tightened, feeling like she just got rejected. But then she noticed the rattling on the door knob. The front door opened and Catra stepped out, a large puffer coat on top of her worn out pyjamas. She walked over, her expression a mix of curiosity and concern.

Adora rolled down the window. “Hey,” she said, trying to keep her voice steady. “Want to go for a drive?”

Catra glanced back at her house, then at Adora, before nodding slowly. “Why not.”

Catra had a lot of questions—of course she did. It's not exactly the norm to have someone rock up at your house in the middle of the night. But Adora never really pulled anything like this. The only other time she could recall was during their senior year just post final exams (and now that she's off to college, that made a lot more sense). And that night, they just drove around for hours, got a coke then came home, virtually all in silence.

Catra was a no-questions kinda girl in times like this. If Adora needed her, she'd be there. And this was no different.

She walked over to the passenger side and got in. Her presence filled the car with a sense of comfort that Adora had been craving.

“So? Where are we going?” Catra asked, fastening her seatbelt.

Adora shrugged, a small smile tugging at her lips. “You’ll see.”

“Are you kidnapping me?” she smirked.

Adora chuckled. “Maybe.”

Adora put the car in gear, and they drove off into the night. The road stretched out before them like a trippy dream. The radio played a soft, nostalgic tune—Chasing Cars which was one of their favourites growing up. It was a slow, haunting melody, the singer's voice almost a whisper against the backdrop of gentle guitar strums.

For a while, they drove in silence, the only sounds coming from the hum of the engine and the music. Adora glanced over at Catra, who stared out the window, lost in her thoughts. Despite the silence, Adora felt better with Catra beside her. It was as if just being together, even without words, made everything a little more bearable.

Eventually, Adora turned onto a familiar road and slowed the car. She pulled up and parked, turning off the engine. The silence that followed was profound, the night air crisp and still.

Catra looked around, confusion written on her face. “Where are we?”

Adora grinned, unbuckling her seatbelt. “We’re at high school.”

“What? Why?”

“Just trust me,” Adora replied, opening her door and stepping out.

Catra hesitated for a moment before following her. They made their way to the edge of the field, where a metal fence blocked their path. Adora found the familiar spot where the fence was slightly bent, creating just enough space for them to squeeze through. She motioned for Catra to follow her, and they slipped under the fence.

The field was dark, the outlines of the buildings barely visible in the moonlight. It was their smaller one at their school. The one reserved for PE classes, as opposed to their other large one for football games located slightly off campus. Adora led Catra towards the middle of the field, their footsteps muffled by the grass.

God, look at this place. It’s like nothing had changed. Maybe the grass was a little longer since it was the school holidays, and it was a little dewier than she was used to. But otherwise, the stands on the sidelines and the blinding lights stayed the same.

“Remember PE classes out here?” Adora said, sticking her hands into her pockets.

Catra laughed softly. “How could I forget? You always took it so seriously. I swear, you treated every lap like it was the Olympics.”

“What can I say? I liked PE. Unlike someone who kept gooding off,”

“Hey, it was all part of the strategy,” Catra replied with a smirk. “If I could make you laugh, I’d count that as a win.”

Adora rolled her eyes playfully. “You were impossible. Coach would get so frustrated with you.”

Catra shrugged. “Someone had to keep things interesting. Otherwise, Coach would start going on his usual dumb rants about how he “nearly made it to the Olympics”. Like, sure Coach.”

They laughed. Eventually, they reached the edge of the field and sat down on the cool grass, looking back at the dark silhouette of their old high school building.

“It looks so different at night,” Catra said quietly, her voice almost a whisper.

“Yeah,” Adora hugged her knees to her chest. “It kind of reminds me of the Annual Ball.”

“The one during Senior Year?” she received a ‘mmm’ as a reply. “Yeah, that year’s music was so bad. They really dropped from the year before.”

“Oh junior year Annual Ball was the best except,”

“The Jason incident?”

“Yeah, the Jason incident.”

They sat there for a while, the cool night air wrapping around them like a blanket.

“Do you ever miss it?” Catra asked, her voice soft.

“Sometimes,” Adora admitted. “Not the schoolwork though. And some of the people. But I miss when things were simpler and less complicated.”

Catra hummed in agreement.

They fell into a comfortable silence. Sitting there, looking at the place where they had grown up, they felt a connection that time and distance couldn't break.

Catra broke the silence, her voice hesitant. "Do you remember the night before you left for college?"

Adora's breath hitched. She was hoping they wouldn't have to talk about it. But simultaneously, she was bursting to talk about it. "Yeah, I remember."

Catra turned to look at her, her eyes searching Adora's face. "You kissed me."

Adora felt her cheeks burn, the memory flooding back. "I did," she whispered.

It was weird. There were certain secrets that could never see the light of day. Like saying them out loud while the sun was out made it so someone could hear them or it would get exposed.

Midnight talks. Those were different. When you whispered secrets in the dead of night, it felt like it wouldn't reach a soul. Like they were the only people in the world that could ever hear it. Secrets. Fears. No one could hear them in the dark, like they were in their own little world.

Those were the best conversations they've ever had before. Nothing felt as real as those moments.

"And then we didn't talk for months," Catra said, her voice tinged with hurt.

Adora swallowed hard, the weight of that moment pressing down on her. "...I'm sorry for that."

Catra sighed, looking back at the school. "I just don't understand why you had to leave like that."

"I-it was a spur-of-the-moment thing. I felt like I needed to… I don't know, to say goodbye in a way that mattered,"

Catra's eyes narrowed. "A spur-of-the-moment thing? So you just kissed me out of nowhere and then disappeared? You didn't think I deserved a real explanation?"

Adora's heart raced, her throat tightening. "I-I don't know! Everything was changing so fast. I don't even know what to say. I was scared."

Catra stood up, frustration evident in her every movement. "Scared? You think you're the only one who was scared? You left

me here to deal with everything on my own. You didn't even have the guts to talk to me about it."

Adora stood as well, her voice rising. "It wasn't like that! I didn't know how to tell you how I felt. It just... happened."

Catra's eyes flashed with anger. "So what? You just acted on a whim and then ran away? You don't get to do that, Adora. You don't get to mess with my head and then vanish."

Adora felt tears welling up in her eyes. "I didn't mean to hurt you. I was confused, and I didn't know what to do. I thought... maybe it would make things clearer, but it just made everything more complicated."

Catra crossed her arms, her voice cold. "You think? You think it didn't mess with my head too? You kissed me and then left me to figure it all out on my own. Do you know how hard that was?"

Adora took a step closer, her voice trembling. "I know it was hard. But I was dealing with my own feelings too. I…" she trailed off. Come on. Come on. Just say it. She internally panicked, thoughts running at thousand miles per hour but also completely empty at the same time. "I can't say it."

"Just say it Adora!"

“I can’t!”

“Why not?! You don’t think you owe it to me? You don’t think I deserve that much?!”

“I liked you Catra!”

The silence of the night filled the air between them. It was like they were a million miles away from each other but simultaneously right next to each other.

Catra’s expression softened slightly, but the hurt was still there. “You liked me?”

Her face burned with embarrassment, her eyes unable to meet hers. “Of course I did. I was embarrassed by it. I didn’t know if you felt the same way.”

Catra took a step closer, her voice softer but still insistent. “And now?”

Adora swallowed hard, feeling the weight of the moment. “I still like you. I’ve always liked you. I just didn’t know how to deal with it because I didn't want to lose our friendship.”

Catra sighed, the tension in her shoulders easing a bit. “So you like me?”

Adora nodded, her heart pounding in her chest. “Yes, Catra. I like you. Obviously.”

Catra took a deep breath, then nodded slowly. “Okay, fine. I like you too.”

They stood there in the cool night air, the reality of their feelings hanging between them. It was a relief to have the truth out in the open, but it brought a new set of complications.

“But what do we do now?” Catra asked, her voice tinged with uncertainty. “This town…”

“I know,”

“They won’t like us,”

“I know,” Adora nodded, fear starting to bubble in her chest. “We can’t let anyone find out…”

Catra looked down at their hands, her fingers brushing against Adora’s. “So where does that leave us?”

Adora took a deep breath, feeling the weight of the question. “I don’t know. Can we figure it out together?”

Catra nodded, a small smile forming on her lips. “Yeah. We’ll figure it out.”

They couldn't muster up the courage to come any closer. There was still a noticeable gap between the two of them.

Catra began to speak again. "Is that why you wanted to meet me tonight?"

"No," Adora shook her head. "Honestly, home kind of sucks right now," she said it with a laugh but it was sarcastic. "My mom sucks. My dad is barely around. I feel like I'm just dealing everything on my own, I guess."

She snickered. "Join the club."

They stood there, shivering hands within the cool night air, the uncertainty of their future looming large, but the connection between them stronger than ever. It wasn’t a perfect resolution, but it was a start.

Chapter 8

The last few days had been a whirlwind for Adora. Her parents had been determined to keep her occupied, filling every moment with a flurry of holiday preparations. She found herself caught up in a relentless cycle of decorating the house, hanging garlands and stringing up lights until her fingers were numb from the cold.

They had spent an entire day picking out the perfect Christmas tree (despite the fact that there was already one up in their living room), trekking through rows of evergreens until they finally agreed on the right one. Then there was the shopping—endless shopping trips to bustling stores, searching for gifts and holiday essentials for their extended family (ones that Adora honestly didn't really care for).

Each day seemed to blur into the next, leaving Adora exhausted but strangely content. Despite the busyness, her mind kept drifting back to Catra and the night they had shared. She replayed their conversation over and over, the truth of their feelings finally out in the open. It felt like a weight had been lifted, but it also left her yearning for more time with Catra, away from the prying eyes of their conservative town. Just the two of them alone. Away from the rest of the world, maybe even the universe.

Finally, after days of being wrapped up in holiday chaos, Adora and Catra had settled on meeting up that night. They had planned something special, something just for them—a secret escape from the world that seemed determined to keep them apart.

As the sun dipped below the horizon, Adora grabbed her keys and slipped out of the house, her heart pounding with anticipation. Though it was one of the coldest of winter nights, the truth was, the excitement she was feeling towards finally spending time with Catra was weirdly keeping her warm. Like her heart was racing so fast her head could barely keep up. She drove to Catra's house, where Catra was already waiting at the end of the driveway, bundled up in a warm coat. Adora smiled as Catra climbed into the car, her presence immediately making everything feel brighter.

"Where to?" Catra asked, fastening her seatbelt.

Adora grinned. "Well, it's a surprise."

They drove through the quiet streets, the town blanketed in a serene, wintry stillness. Adora still couldn't get used to being back to be honest. It had been a while now, and she expected herself to just ease back into the normality of their small quaint town; and everything she had ever known for 18 years. But it was different. The town just felt different. She felt different.

She didn't look at all these landmarks—the restaurants, the library, the school—like they were a part of her identity anymore. They looked like relics from an old distant memory. Like she had lived through those moments a whole lifetime ago.

But what felt real though, even with all these dream-like, hazy landscapes which passed her—was Catra. The person who sat in her driver's seat, gazing out the window, not even noticing how

Adora had kept throwing glances at her while driving along the empty road. She smiled to herself.

Adora navigated them to the outskirts of town, where a small, secluded lake lay hidden among the trees. It was a place they had discovered together years ago. 8th grade excursion. Partial fishing trip. Mostly a trip to test the water purity level. And there was one kid that fell into the water. *Damn it Kyle.*

When they arrived, Adora led Catra to the edge of the lake. The moonlight reflected off the surface of the water, casting a gentle glow over everything. They spread out a blanket on the grassy shore and sat down, the cool night air crisp and invigorating.

Adora pulled out a thermos of hot chocolate from her bag, pouring two steaming cups. "I thought we could use something to keep us warm," she said, handing one to Catra.

Catra smiled, taking the cup and wrapping her hands around it. "You always think of everything."

They sipped their hot chocolate in comfortable silence, the warmth seeping into their bodies. After a while, Adora reached into her bag again and pulled out a small, twinkling string of fairy lights. She wound them around a nearby tree, the soft glow creating a magical, intimate atmosphere.

“This is perfect,” Catra said softly, looking around in awe. “What made you so romantic all of a sudden?”

Adora sheepishly shrugged. “I don’t know. I wanted to do something special. Especially because I haven’t seen you for days.”

“Well I mean, you hadn't seen me for months before that so,” she took a sip of her hot chocolate. “I guess I deserve this.”

Adora laughed. “Typical.”

They lay back on the blanket, looking up at the stars. The sky was clear, the stars shining brightly against the dark canvas of the night. Adora felt Catra’s hand find hers, their fingers intertwining.

“You know, it’s been just over a week until I came back,” Adora muttered. “...it’s been crazy.”

“Yeah,” Catra’s words fell to her chest. “And it’s a few days until Christmas. Another week to New Years.”

“Yep…" she sighed. "...are you trying to ask me when I’m going back to college?”

“Kind of, yeah,”

“I’m not too sure yet,” she laid back onto her elbows. “I was going to stay until New Years. Like, the day. But now I’ve seen you and…” she glanced over to meet Catra’s intense stare. “I don’t know if I can leave.”

“Then don’t,”

She snickered. “You know I have to.”

“Why?” Catra abruptly sat up.

“Because everything is there. My stuff, my dorm, my—”

“I will literally drive and pick up everything myself and drag it back,”

She knew she was half joking but to be honest, the determination in her eyes was convincing. “You know I can’t. I like it there. I love my life,” she took a sip from her cup, noticing how Catra’s gaze faltered a little. “But I’d love it a lot more if you came.”

“I don’t know…” Catra took another sip of her drink. “You make it sound great, don’t get me wrong. But with my mom and work, I

don’t know if I can just leave everything and go.”

“But if you explain it to your mom and get a new job and—”

“It’s not that easy,” she squeezed her hand. “You know that.”

“But—”

“Can you drop it?” her words weren’t rough. They were soft around the edges like she was pleading.

She grinned. “Okay.”

“God, what’s gonna happen to us?” Catra said it with a laugh but it was heavily laced with sadness.

“We’ll figure it out though. I just know it,”

“But we’re eventually going to run out of time…” there was another bit of silence. “Am I…just a phase?”

“No!” she sprung up, her empty cup toppling from her hands to grab her by the shoulders. “Don’t ever say that.”

“Sorry, I just wanted to make sure that I’m not like…a holiday fling,”

“You’re more to me than that. Always,”

“So what are we then?”

“I don’t know,”

“Do you expect me to think of you as a best friend after all of this? Because I’m telling you now, I can’t go back,”

“I don’t want to. I like us as…this. I like us now,”

“Good.”

They fell into another pit of silence. Like they had a million more questions to ask but didn't want to push the other too hard.

Catra was the one to fill the air. "...how do you know everything's going to work out?"

Adora shrugged. "I just do."

"And if it doesn't?"

She kind of snickered. Catra snapped at her with an intense glare. "I mean, when has it not? It's us we're talking about Catra. You. Me. No one else. When have we not overcome an issue together, right?"

She caved a little. "Yeah, I guess you're right."

"See! That's the spirit,"

"You better not go back to not talking to me again,"

"Hey, to be fair I didn't even know you had a phone. I couldn't get a hold of you," Adora took a sip of the hot chocolate. "And now that I've got it, I haven't stopped texting you, right?"

"Yeah, that's true."

Catra buried her face into the hot chocolate, letting the steam cover her expression. She wanted to believe her, she did. But she just couldn't handle being abandoned by her again. She didn't want to be left all alone to pick up the pieces. But simultaneously,

she couldn't just leave. That wasn't an option...right? With her mom, work, even her friends. This is all she never knew. But Adora.

She shook her head.

"So...that new apple pie recipe you sent me,"

She hummed then jolted a little in surprise. "Yeah? Was it good?"

"Oh nah it was garbage,"

"You're kidding."

Chapter 9

Over the next week, Adora finally mustered up the courage to spend more time with Catra out in the open. Instead of treating it like their dirty little secret; one which could only exist in the middle of nowhere in the dead of night, Adora felt this feeling of… confidence that she couldn't quite describe. I mean, as long as no one knew they were "together" together it should be fine, right? It would actually be weirder if the town knew she was back but she wasn't with Catra since it was essentially common knowledge that they were glued at the hip. With that rationale, she felt the confidence to actually go out like they used to.

So, Adora and Catra spent almost every waking moment together. Adora would escape from her house early in the morning before her mom could complain, and would come home too late for her to even bother staying up for her. And after a while, her mom just gave up, realising there was no way she could win this.

Even with that awkward family tension in the house, Adora didn't care. Their time together was perfect. Simple joys, feeling like slipping into a well-worn, beloved sweater. This was ultimately what she wanted from her Christmas holidays.

Like one day they went to the local mall. They wandered through the corridors, laughing and window shopping. They tried on glamorous dresses to goofy suits and left every store empty handed (though they took more pictures than they'd like to admit).

And on another day, they visited the old park where they used to play as kids. They sat on the swings, letting the crisp winter air fill their lungs as they talked about everything on their minds. From guilty-pleasure TV shows to recently listened to albums. They spent hours there, swinging back and forth, the rhythm of their movement in sync with their conversation.

On another outing, they drove out to the edge of town to visit their favorite lookout spot. The place where they could see the whole town spread out beneath them, the lights twinkling like stars. They brought hot chocolate in thermoses, wrapped themselves in blankets, and talked about everything and nothing, the warmth of their drinks and each other’s presence keeping the cold at bay.

And one particularly chilly afternoon, they decided to stay in and have a movie marathon. They curled up on the couch in Catra’s living room, surrounded by blankets and pillows. They watched all their old favorites, the ones they used to watch during sleepovers, laughing and quoting lines that had become inside jokes over the years. The smell of popcorn filled the air, and they felt like they were kids again, without a care in the world.

By the time the week was over, it felt like nothing between them had changed. The awkwardness and distance that had once separated them melted away, replaced by the familiar, comforting bond they had always shared. And for a split moment, Adora actually imagined what her life was like if she stayed here. She wondered for a second if every day could be like this for them—where she'd see Catra and go on these amazing adventures around their familiar little town.

That particular afternoon, Adora and Catra were lounging in the latter's living room, the sunlight filtering through the curtains, casting a warm, golden glow across the room. The house was quiet, with Catra's mom out at work, and the only sounds were the occasional rustling of pages from the books they were reading and the faint hum of the heater.

Adora's phone buzzed, and she glanced at it, her eyes widening.

BOW: hey

BOW: you read to call?

She had completely forgotten. She had agreed to call Bow and Glimmer that day. To be honest, with the whirlwind of activities and sentimentality filling each waking moment, she sometimes found herself forgetting about college all together, including both Bow and Glimmer.

She bit her lip, feeling a twinge of guilt.

"Hey, um, I totally forgot I was supposed to call Bow and Glimmer today," Adora said, glancing at Catra. "Do you mind if I call them now?"

Catra looked up from her book, her expression neutral but a flicker of reluctance in her eyes. "Sure, go ahead."

Adora hesitated for a moment before dialling. The phone rang twice before Bow's cheerful voice answered.

"Hey, Adora! Glimmer's here too, one sec—"

There was a brief shuffling sound, followed by Glimmer's excited voice. "Hey, Adora! We've been waiting to hear from you!"

"Hey, guys," Adora said, forcing a smile. "I'm actually hanging out with Catra right now. Do you mind if she joins the call?"

"Of course not!" Bow said, his tone enthusiastic. "Hi, Catra! It’s so cool to finally meet you. Well, I guess hear from you haha."

"Hey," Catra replied curtly, barely looking up.

Glimmer's voice was bright and cheerful. "So, Catra, what do you do for fun? Adora told us a bit about you, but we'd love to know more!"

Catra shrugged, her response short and dismissive. "Not much, really. Just hang out, I guess."

Bow tried to keep the conversation going. "Do you have any favorite movies or hobbies? Adora mentioned you guys watch a lot of movies together."

"Yeah, sometimes," Catra said, her tone flat.

Adora felt the awkwardness settling in the room. She could see that Catra was clearly uncomfortable and uninterested in the conversation. She cleared her throat, forcing a smile. "You know what, guys? We actually had something planned, and I totally forgot about it. Can I call you back later?"

There was a brief pause before Bow and Glimmer both responded, their tones still bright but with a hint of awkwardness. "Sure, Adora. Talk to you later!"

Adora quickly ended the call, sighing as she put her phone down. She looked at Catra, who had already returned to her book, her expression closed off.

"What the hell was that?" Adora snapped, frustration bubbling to the surface.

Catra didn't even look up, her tone dripping with sarcasm. "What?"

"You were so rude for no reason," Adora said, her voice rising. "They're really nice."

Catra finally looked up, her eyes narrowing. "Well, I don't know them."

Adora threw her hands up in exasperation. "They're my friends, Catra! You were so dismissive and cold."

Catra's expression hardened, a spark of anger flaring in her eyes. "Oh, so now it's my fault for not being chummy with your new friends?"

"It's not about being chummy," Adora shot back. "It's about basic decency. You didn't even try."

Catra's voice rose, her frustration mirroring Adora's. "Well, maybe it's hard for me to be decent to the people you replaced me with!"

Adora froze, her heart pounding. "Replaced you? Is that what you think?"

Catra's eyes blazed with hurt and anger. "What else am I supposed to think, Adora? You leave, you don't talk to me for months, and then you come back and act like everything's fine, but it's not. You've moved on. You've got new friends. You don't need me anymore."

Adora shook her head, her voice trembling with emotion. "It's not like that, Catra. They're different. They're not a replacement."

"Sure feels like it," Catra muttered, crossing her arms defensively.

Adora stepped closer, pleading with her eyes. "Catra, please. They mean a lot to me, but so do you. They're different kinds of friendships. One doesn't replace the other."

Catra looked away, her jaw clenched. "I don't know, Adora. It just feels like you've moved on from us, from me."

Adora's voice softened, filled with sincerity. "I haven't moved on from you. I could never. I've really enjoyed the last few days. It's been great."

"Then why do you have to leave?"

That was honestly a good point—Adora thought it but she would never utter it out loud. When she made up her mind to go to college during their Senior Year, everything felt more set in stone. She had a goal and she treated it like any other goal she's ever had—she would do everything in her power to make it come true. But now she's back for the first time in a year and it's just...different. She thought she'd hate it but to be honest, she didn't. It's been a lot of fun. And it's been comfortable. There's no

getting lost, or meeting creepy people or finding out that your favourite restaurant's closed down. Everything stood still here, like time never touched its land. Truth be told, sometimes, this party of reality was a lot easier to deal with.

Adora sighed. "Look, I can't pretend like college hasn't changed things. It has. But that doesn't mean you don't matter to me anymore. You matter so much."

Catra's eyes flicked back to Adora, searching for truth in her words. "I just... I don't want to be left behind again."

Adora reached out, taking Catra's hand in hers. "You won't be," *don't promise her. Don't promise her. You can't keep this promise.* "I promise," Catra eased into a small smile. "But you have to give them a chance. For me."

Catra sighed, the fight draining out of her. She looked at Adora, seeing the earnest plea in her eyes. "Fine. I'll give them a chance."

Adora's face broke into a relieved smile. "Thank you, Catra. It means a lot to me."

Catra nodded, her grip on Adora's hand tightening slightly. "Just... don't forget about me, okay?"

"Never," Adora said firmly. "You're irreplaceable."

With a deep breath, Adora picked up her phone again and called Bow and Glimmer back.

"Oh by the way we're going to FaceTime this time,"

"What?"

They picked up almost immediately, their faces filling the screen with expectant smiles.

"Hey, sorry about that," Adora started. "Turns out our plans were for a different day. We're not busy now. And, um, Catra wanted to say sorry."

Catra groaned but took the phone from Adora, looking at Bow and Glimmer with a reluctant smile. "Sorry about earlier. I was... caught off guard."

Bow and Glimmer exchanged a glance, their smiles widening. "No problem at all," Glimmer said brightly. "We get it."

“I mean Glimmer went crazy when I started hanging out with this new friend too so I get it,” Bow joked.

“I didn’t go “crazy” but sure, it went something like that,” Glimmer added.

“It was a little crazy but—”

Adora interjected. “Okay, okay guys,” she laughed. “Anyways, I’ve been meaning to ask Bow how far you got in that book I got you for your birthday.”

Bow's face lit up. "Actually I already finished it! And I decided to get the next book in the series. The world-building, the characters—everything is just so well done.”

Adora settled back, feeling a wave of relief wash over her. “Good because I actually got the book because Catra loves it so much.”

Catra's eyes widened with excitement. "Wait, are you talking about 'The Chronicles of Arathorn'?”

Bow gasped. “Yes!”

“Oh my god, I love that franchise! Did you get to the part where the Dragon Queen finally meets the Shadow King?"

Glimmer groaned playfully, covering her ears. "Spoilers! Spoilers! I'm a slow reader and I haven't gotten up to that part yet."

Bow laughed, waving a hand dismissively. “Don’t worry, Glimmer, we won’t spoil anything for you. But Catra, what did you think about that twist with the Moonstone Blade?”

Catra’s face lit up. “Oh, that was epic! The way they built up to it was just incredible. I didn’t see it coming at all!”

Adora watched as Catra animatedly discussed the book with Bow, her initial reluctance melting away. She felt a warm glow in her chest, happy to see her friends getting along.

Glimmer chimed in, her eyes sparkling with curiosity. “I can’t wait to get to that part. So far, I’m really loving the character development. Especially with Elara. She’s so strong and determined.”

Catra nodded enthusiastically. “Elara’s journey is one of my favorites. She has so much depth and complexity. You’re going to love what happens next.”

Bow leaned back, a satisfied smile on his face. “It's one of those series that just pulls you in and doesn’t let go.”

Adora couldn’t help but to insert herself in, finally snapping out of her gaze. “My favourite part is the magic system. Easily. It’s just phenomenal.”

Glimmer nodded eagerly. “Absolutely. If I had the ability to teleport, I would literally never stop using it.”

Bow grinned, his eyes darting back and forth between Catra and Adora who were know exchanging light laughter. "Aw Adora, Catra's so cute! No wonder you're in love with her."

The colour ran up her cheeks. Her heart skipped a beat and voice hitched. “Okay, gotta go. Bye guys!" She quickly ended the call, her cheeks still burning.

Catra turned to her, a teasing smile playing on her lips. "Wow, Adora, that's so rude to cut off their call like that."

Adora playfully nudged her. "Shut up."

Chapter 10

Ah Christmas. Christmas is a time for giving, presents, joy, family...sucks when you hate your family.

Snow swirled outside in a relentless blizzard. The storm was so fierce that it had snowed everyone in. Adora's house was filled to the brim with family members from both sides, making it a chaotic whirlpool that she really couldn’t deal with right now.

Look, when she was younger, she loved Christmas. She loved looking after all her cousins and catching up with her uncles. But the more she grew up, the more the expectations began to come out. When are you getting married? When are you having kids? She didn’t understand why any of that mattered.

Adora stood by the large window in her dining room which faced the road. Every inch of the exterior was adorned with decorations. Twinkling lights in every colour imaginable outlined the roof, windows, and doorways, casting a warm, inviting glow that reflected off the freshly fallen snow. In the front yard stood an inflatable Santa Claus that stood at least ten feet tall. Beside him, a group of reindeers appeared mid-flight, their sleek bodies illuminated by hidden lights that made them seem almost lifelike. A sleigh, piled high with faux gifts wrapped in glittering paper, completed the scene.

It was excessive. And somehow the interior was worse.

Stepping into the house was like entering a chaotic kaleidoscope of Christmas clichés. The living room was an explosion of clashing colors and kitschy decorations, each corner vying for attention in a way that felt overwhelming rather than festive. The walls were plastered with garlands, tinsel, and bows in every shade of red and green, creating a dizzying effect that made it hard to know where to look first.

The Christmas tree they'd purchased was dominating the centre of the room, its branches sagging under the weight of too many ornaments. Gaudy baubles in mismatched colours hung alongside blinking multicoloured lights, making the tree look like a chaotic carnival attraction. Tinsel was haphazardly draped over the branches, and a crooked star topped the tree, tilting precariously to one side.

Literally every available surface was covered in decorations. The coffee table held a centrepiece of fake holly and poinsettias, surrounded by a nativity scene that looked like it had been painted by a child, the colours running together in a messy blend. End tables sported mismatched Christmas-themed doilies and an array of scented candles that filled the air with competing aromas of cinnamon, pine, and peppermint, creating an overwhelming olfactory assault.

The living room was packed with relatives, all wrapped in Christmas sweaters that ranged from charmingly festive to garishly ugly.

She constantly forgot how crazy big her family is, and how she was barely close to any of them. At least for the last few years anyways. Adora could basically chalk it up to the following:

- Major divorce on her dad's side which tore the family apart (to be honest, the wife was a lot nicer than her uncle anyways and deserved better);
- Some weird allegations about her now dead grandma;
- Even worse allegations about her very alive grandpa;
- Her baby cousins are becoming overly spoiled. They're IPad kids on crack. Can't deal with no. Never drink water, only soda;
- Every member somehow became more and more conservative as time went on. Some just seemed to get more racist and homophobic somehow. And others just straight up believed that Google was leftist propaganda. She wished she was lying about that one.

She *really* hated that last one.

God, I wish Catra was here . Adora glanced at her phone for the billionth time today. Catra's replies were inconsistent. I mean, it was Christmas. Adora didn't want to be that clingy partner who kept texting over and over but she couldn't help it. She groaned to herself. She felt pathetic. But even so, she slipped out of the dining room, navigating the crowded house until she reached the back door. She walked out.

The cold hit her immediately, but the crisp air was refreshing after the stuffy warmth of the house. Snow crunched under her boots as she walked to the fence at the edge of the yard.

And there, on the other side, was Catra. She looked up, her eyes widening in surprise before softening into a familiar smirk.

"What are you doing out here?" Adora asked, her breath visible in the freezing air.

Catra shrugged, her hands buried in the pockets of her thick coat. "Needed some air. And I guess I was hoping to see you."

Adora smiled, feeling her heart lighten despite the cold. "Well, you found me."

They stood there for a moment, just looking at each other. The wind howled, but it felt like a private little world they had created, just the two of them.

“You know you could’ve just texted me, right?”

“Eh, the real thing is better,” Catra glanced down at her toes. “So…want to come over?” Catra asked, her voice tentative but hopeful.

Adora’s eyes lit up. “Are you sure?”

Catra smirked. “Yeah, it’s a small madhouse in there. But I figured we could escape together. Maybe hang out in my room?”

Adora grinned. “Lead the way.”

She hoisted herself up on the wooden fence and flipped over. Catra grabbed Adora’s hand, her fingers warm despite the cold, and they ran through the snow towards Catra’s house. They slipped through the back door, Catra peeking around to make sure no one was watching.

The warmth of the house enveloped them, and they dashed past the cosy living room where a few relatives were lounging. Catra's mom was laughing with her sisters. They were sitting around a small Christmas tree, sharing stories and sipping hot cocoa, the lights from the tree casting a warm glow on their faces.

The house was small but inviting. It felt homier, more intimate, than the chaos at Adora’s house.

Catra led Adora up the narrow staircase and into her bedroom. The room was warm, with posters of bands and movies adorning the walls. An electric blanket was spread out on the bed, already heated and inviting. On the nightstand were two steaming mugs of hot chocolate, complete with marshmallows.

“Wow, did you anticipate me coming over?” Adora said with an impressed expression.

“Maybe.”

They collapsed onto the bed, laughing softly as they settled under the electric blanket. Adora took one of the mugs, the warmth seeping into her cold fingers.

"This is much better," Adora said, stretching out beside Catra. "You're so romantic."

"Yeah, I can be romantic when I try," Catra replied, smirking. "Hey actually, I got you something."

Catra reached under the bed and pulled out a small, wrapped gift.

Adora's eyes widened with surprise. "You did? I got you something too!" She reached into her pocket and pulled out a similarly wrapped package.

They exchanged presents, tearing into the wrapping paper with excitement. Catra unwrapped a delicate silver bracelet with a tiny, engraved charm. She looked up at Adora, her eyes shining.

"It's amazing. Thank you."

Adora blushed, looking pleased. "I'm glad you like it."

Adora opened her gift to find a hand-knitted scarf in shades of blue and green. She wrapped it around her neck, grinning. "Did you make this?"

Catra nodded. "I did. Thought it'd keep you warm in this crazy weather."

"I love it," Adora said softly, pulling Catra into a quick hug.

They pulled the blanket over their shoulders, huddling together as they watched the snow falling outside. The world was quiet, blanketed in white, and it felt like they were the only two people in existence.

"Merry Christmas, Adora," Catra whispered.

"Merry Christmas, Catra."

There was a moment of silence, filled only with the sound of their breathing and the soft hum of the heater. Adora turned to Catra, her heart pounding in her chest.

"Can I… you know…"

"What?" Catra asked, her voice teasing.

“Kiss you… again. Properly this time.”

Catra’s eyes sparkled with amusement and something deeper. “Only if you promise not to run.”

They both laughed, the sound mingling with the warmth of the room. Then, Adora leaned in, her heart racing as their lips met. It was soft and tentative at first, but then Catra’s arms wrapped around her, pulling her closer, and the kiss deepened.

Everything else faded away—the snowstorm, the chaos of their families, the uncertainty of the future. In that moment, it was just them, together, sharing a kiss that felt like coming home.

When they finally pulled apart, both were breathless and smiling.

“I won’t run,” Adora promised softly, her forehead resting against Catra’s. “Not anymore.”

“Good,” Catra whispered back. “Because I’m not letting you go.”

They settled back under the blanket, holding each other close, and watched the snow continue to fall outside, feeling perfectly at peace.

Chapter 11

Right about 2PM the day after Christmas, the extended family began trickling home. The living room was a mess of crumpled wrapping paper, half-empty glasses, and stray bits of tinsel. Adora absently gathered the trash, just like her mom ordered her to, though her mind elsewhere the entire time.

"What did you think of that party?" her mom asked, a bright note of satisfaction in her voice.

Adora shrugged, her thoughts drifting back to the night before. There was a faint smile to her lips, like she was in daze. "I think it was okay."

"Oh the turkey was amazing wasn't it? I thought I put it in for too long but it ended up being amazing. Oh! And the tree. Oh gosh the tree. I'm so glad I chose that blue tinsel instead of the green like your father suggested because it just made everything pop, don't you think?"

"Mhm…"

Truth was Adora could barely hear her. Her mind was just lost in the memories of the best night ever with Catra. Those moments that were stolen away from the party. God, she wished that moment lasted forever.

Suddenly, her mom’s voice broke through her reverie. “Where did you end up going last night? I feel like you were barely here.”

“Oh, to my room,” Adora replied quickly.

“That’s strange, I peeked in and you weren’t there.”

“I must’ve been in the bathroom at the time then,” Adora said, trying to keep her tone light and casual. "I drank so much eggnog last night so..."

“Hm,” her mom let it slide, moving on. “Though, there is one thing I didn’t like.”

“What, Mom?”

“Your outfit.”

Adora blinked in surprise. “What?”

“Your outfit. I told you to change,” her mom’s tone was firm, as if she was discussing a great offence.

Adora sighed. “I liked my outfit. It was just plain trousers and a sweater.”

It was a nice fluffy sweater that she got at that mall the other day with Catra. The one that had big arms but was fitted around her waist (and the same one that Catra said suited her like a glove, essentially making her fall in love with it).

“But it’s Christmas and all our family was over, you should’ve worn something more…pretty. You know, those pink frilly dresses you used to wear when you were little,” that made Adora roll her eyes, “Oh you used to be so cute. With those bows in your hair. Oh! Remember when I used to braid your hair?”

Adora groaned. “Mom…”

“It’s true darling!” Her mom’s voice sharpened.

“I like my clothes now,” Adora said, trying to keep her frustration in check. “I bought that sweater at the mall with Catra. I think it looks good.”

“Oh, Catra again. What happened to my little girl? The one who loved dresses and bows and pink? You were my little princess.”

“Mom, I never liked any of that stuff. You liked that stuff,”

Her mom's face softened, but her voice remained firm. "But you're still my little girl."

"I'm not a little girl!" Adora shouted, her voice echoing in the suddenly silent room. The air between them thickened with tension. Adora took a deep breath, her voice trembling. "I've grown up. I'm at college, and I'm happier than I've ever been. But you don't like me for the person that I actually am."

She threw down the decorations she was holding, the sound of them hitting the floor startling in the quiet room. Without another word, she stormed out the door.

"Adora, come back!" her mom called after her, but Adora didn't stop. She didn't look back.

She marched straight across the yards and up to Catra's house, her heart pounding in her chest. The adrenaline made her knock even harsher than she intended to.

A moment later, Catra opened the door, confusion etched on her face. "Adora? What's going on?"

"Can we hang out?" Adora asked, desperation clear in her voice.

Catra frowned. “You know I would love to, but I can’t. I need to clean up after Christmas.”

“Please, I need you,” Adora pleaded, her eyes shining with urgency.

Catra sighed, but she couldn’t say no to that look. “Fine, give me a sec.” She grabbed her coat and keys, and they stepped out into the crisp winter air.

The day after Christmas was unseasonably warm, but there was still a chill that lingered, a reminder of the season. They walked in silence for a while, the sound of their footsteps crunching against the frosty ground filling the void.

Finally, Catra broke the silence. “What’s wrong?”

“I had a massive fight with my mom,” Adora confessed, her voice cracking. “It’s like the third one since I’ve come back. I needed to let off steam. God. I hate this town, I hate my mom, I hate everything about here.”

Catra cringed a little at Adora's words. "...Is that why you had to leave?” her voice was soft. “You just couldn’t deal with these problems anymore?”

Adora nodded, biting her lip to keep the tears at bay.

Catra sighed. “Well, you can’t run away from your problems, Adora.”

“That’s not what I—”

“But it is,” Catra interrupted. “You thought you could run away to college and hope everything would go away. But it didn’t. You just wanted to ignore the fact that this town will continue to be close-minded and your mom isn’t going to be happy with the way you want to be. That’s the truth.”

Adora shook her head. “I feel like this isn’t what this is about.”

“You can’t run away from your problems, Adora. They still exist. I still exist,”

“You weren’t a problem. You were never a problem,” Adora said, her voice pained. “I just had to leave because everything else was too much and I couldn’t do it anymore. And my mom is just too much and I can’t. I hate this life. I hate this lie. It’s not you. You know I care about you more than anything.”

Catra’s expression softened a bit. Everything she had planned to say (and to probably just yell) melted away after seeing Adora’s face on the verge of tears. She just backed up a bit and uttered a small, “Do you want to talk about it?”

Adora sighed, running a hand through her hair. “Yeah, I guess I do.”

They sat down on the curb, the cold concrete a sharp contrast to the warmth of their shared moment. Adora took a deep breath, trying to gather her thoughts.

“My mom has always had these expectations about what she wants me to be,” Adora began. “She wants me to be feminine and soft and girly, just like her...but I’m none of those things. I don't like those things. I’ve always been an overachiever...I always wanted to be strong and smart, and instead of being proud of that, she sees it as a flaw. It’s like no matter what I achieve, it’s never good enough because it’s not what she wants.”

Catra listened quietly, her eyes fixed on Adora’s face, absorbing every word.

“Do you remember when I won the science fair?”

“Which year?”

“10th grade. When my project when to states?"

“Sure do,”

Adora continued, her voice tinged with bitterness. “I worked so hard on my project, stayed up nights, did all this research. I was so proud of myself."

"Yeah I remember it. It was super cool,"

Adora gave into a little smile at Catra's compliment, but faded as the memory continued to play in her mind. "But when I came home with the trophy, all she said was, ‘That’s nice, but maybe next time you can wear a dress to the award ceremony.’ Like, that’s all she cared about. Not my hard work, not my achievement, just how I looked...”

Adora’s voice wavered, but she pushed on. “It’s always like that. I got straight A’s, and she’d say I should focus more on being sociable. I broke the school record for track, and she’d complain about my messy hair. I’ve always been adventurous, always wanted to push myself, to see what I could achieve. But to her, every success made me less of the girl she wanted me to be.”

Catra nodded, her expression softening even more. “That sounds really hard, Adora. I didn’t know your mom was that…intense.”

“And it’s like, I thought about staying and trying to change myself, to be what she wanted. Like, I really tried to convince myself that I wanted to stay and wanted this life she envisioned for me," she snickered at the thought. "Like do you remember Max?"

"Which one? Max G or Max J?"

"Max M. One in the year above us?"

"Ohh, oboe player,"

"Yep," Adora rolled her eyes. "Mom tried to set me up with him."

Catra bursted out into laughter, "What?! As if!"

"Yep," she groaned into her hand. "She was in cahoots with his parents and she had apparently imagined a whole white-picket fence life for Max and I..."

"Oh that's...yeah that's bad,"

"And for a second I actually thought about it. I thought it would make her happy,"

"You don't actually feel that way anymore, right?"

"God no," Adora laughed. "I kind of woke up one day in senior grade and thought...*screw that*. That sounds awful. I would hate this life. Like I realized I love myself too much to do that."

Adora whipped her head around to Catra, meeting her face to face. Her eyes downturned like she was pleading to get this message across to her.

She spoke again, "I had to leave, to reach my full potential as a person. I couldn't do that here, under her constant criticism. I needed to go somewhere I could be myself, without feeling like I was constantly disappointing her."

Catra reached out and took Adora's hand, giving it a reassuring squeeze. "I get it. You needed to find a place where you could thrive."

"Exactly," Adora said, her voice softening. "But it's still hard, you know? I feel like I'm always going to be running from her expectations, always going to be fighting to be seen for who I am, not who she wants me to be."

Catra nodded. "It sounds exhausting."

"It is," Adora admitted. "But being away, being at college, it's helped. I've found people who appreciate me for who I am, not who they want me to be. It's just… coming back here, it brings up all those old feelings. And it's hard to deal with."

Catra sighed, her grip on Adora's hand tightening. "I'm sorry, Adora. I didn't realize it was that bad."

"It's okay," Adora said, her voice soft. "I'm just glad you're here. Talking to you helps."

They sat in silence for a moment, the winter air cold but the connection between them warm and comforting. Finally, Catra spoke.

"Adora, you're amazing just the way you are. Don't let anyone make you feel like you're not."

Adora smiled, a genuine smile that reached her eyes. "Thank you, Catra. That means a lot."

Catra leaned in, their foreheads touching. "And just so you know, I'm here for you. Always."

Adora's heart swelled with emotion. "I know. And I'm here for you too."

They sat there, wrapped in each other's presence, finding solace in their shared understanding. For a moment, the cold, harsh

world outside seemed to fade away, leaving just the two of them, together against all odds.

As they sat there, Catra's thoughts began to shift. She felt like a selfish idiot. When Adora first left, she felt abandoned. ~~Daddy issues do that to you~~. She felt like she was kicked to the curb. But now, hearing Adora pour her heart out, she realized that Adora hadn't left her; she had escaped from a life that was suffocating her.

Adora needed to leave. Catra could see that now. Staying in this town, under the oppressive expectations of her mother. Catra felt a pang of guilt, recognizing her own selfishness in wanting Adora to stay. She had been so focused on her own feelings of abandonment that she hadn't considered how much Adora had been struggling.

And she felt like even more of an idiot for missing the signs. She had been friends with Adora since they were actual children. She'd stayed over her house all the time. She's seen Adora's mom more times than her actual mom at times. Now that she had a moment to look back on those moments, everything started flooding back to her.

Like, now that she was genuinely thinking about it, everything Adora was saying made sense. How Adora's mom would straighten her dress everytime they got home from school. Or how she's yell at her when they played out in the mud. Or after award ceremonies where her mom would brush her fingers through her hair between taking pictures.

God, I've been so stupid, Catra thought. *I've been so self-centered.*

Catra squeezed Adora's hand, a gesture meant to comfort her but also to steady herself. She knew, deep down, that Adora didn't belong in this small, close-minded town. Adora was meant for bigger things, and Catra couldn't let her be tied down by the expectations of people who couldn't see her worth.

They held each other, a silent promise passing between them. Catra knew it wouldn't be easy, but she was determined to support Adora, no matter what. Because Adora deserved to shine, and Catra would do everything in her power to make sure she never felt tied down again.

Chapter 12

Catra trudged home through the snowy streets. She already hated work. It was worse when it was a midnight shift.

And the tips didn't justify the abuse from customers she'd gotten that night. Usually, midnight shifts had the best people—mostly truckers and maybe some annoying drunk teenagers but give them coke and they shut up. But tonight was different. They were impatient, entitled, and seemingly determined to ruin her night. There was the elderly woman who complained endlessly about the temperature of her coffee, despite Catra ensuring it was piping hot. Then there was the group of teenagers who left a huge mess at their table, barely acknowledging her when she politely asked them to clean up after themselves. It was a night filled with petty complaints and entitled attitudes, leaving Catra feeling drained and irritated.

And now it was 5AM in the morning, and she was walking in a ginormous, old coat walking home in pitch darkness. As she walked, her thoughts turned to Adora. They had talked earlier, and Catra couldn't shake the way Adora's words had resonated with her. She always thought Adora was near-perfect, with her effortless charm and seemingly perfect life. Adora excelled in everything she did—top of the sports teams, top of her classes, always with a go-getter attitude that inspired others around her.

She was popular, not in the typical cheerleader or party-throwing sense, but among their grade. She had a natural magnetism that drew people to her. Adora was confident. She was successful. Maybe to a point that most of Catra's friends were really just Adora's friends. Sometimes it felt like she was just there for the

ride, though in some ways, she didn't care because she just liked Adora too much.

Before Scorpia came into her life through a random science project, Catra had often felt like an outsider. She was the girl with the absent father in this town filled with nuclear families and normality. She struggled with subjects like math that seemed to come effortlessly to Adora. She couldn’t afford a dress for the Annual Ball and had to borrow one of Adora’s. In the town’s eyes, she was the weirdo, the outsider, the one who wouldn’t be invited anywhere if Adora hadn’t vouched for her.

But tonight, as she trudged through the snow-covered streets, Catra realized something. Adora had always been too good for this town, too good for the narrow-minded judgments that plagued it. Adora had left for college to pursue her dreams, to escape the confines of a place that couldn’t appreciate her for who she truly was. And as Catra reflected on their conversation earlier, she started kind of understanding that Adora’s departure wasn’t just about leaving Catra behind—it was about Adora finding herself, breaking free from the expectations and limitations that stifled her. And for a moment, Catra wondered if she needed that for herself too.

Catra trudged wearily into her house, feeling the weight of exhaustion settle heavily on her shoulders. The warmth inside was a stark contrast to the biting cold outside, and she shed her coat and boots with a grateful sigh. As she moved towards the kitchen to fix herself a much-needed cup of tea, her phone buzzed with a message from Adora.

ADORA: Morning

Catra couldn't help but smile despite her fatigue.

CATRA: hey

CATRA: I can barely stand but I want tea before I sleep lol.

A few moments passed before Adora responded.

ADORA: I left a box of chamomile tea on your back door.

Catra chuckled softly to herself.

CATRA: you’re the best

Adora always had a way of making her feel cared for, even from a distance. Retrieving the tea from where Adora had left it, Catra made herself a soothing cup in the kitchen. She peered up from the counter which overlooked their tight dining room.

At the wooden table, her mom was sitting on the end chair. She had just woken up for the day, wrapped up in a fluffy coat. She had a piping hot coffee in one hand and she mindlessly scrolled on her phone with the other.

"Hey, Mom," Catra greeted quietly, setting her tea down on the counter.

Her mom glanced up at her. “Long day?"

Catra nodded, taking a sip of her tea. "Yeah, the usual. Rude customers, spilled drinks, the whole deal."

“At least you’re home now," her mom took her last gulp of coffee and gave a sigh. "Listen, I might head over to Bonnie’s for a bit soon."

“Who?”

“Danny’s mom,”

“Right…” Catra nodded again, absently stirring her tea.

As her mom puttered around past her and to the kitchen sink, Catra's thoughts drifted back to her earlier conversation with Adora. And then, almost impulsively, Catra found herself voicing a question that had been lingering in the back of her mind for longer than she cared to admit.

"Have you ever thought of leaving?" she asked, her voice quieter than she intended.

Her mom paused, her hands stilling on the counter. "What?"

Catra swallowed, feeling the weight of her words settle between them. "Have you ever thought about leaving this town?"

Her mom sighed softly. "Not really. Our house was a gift from your dad's parents. It's nice, it fits us, and there's no mortgage. If we moved, there'd be rent to pay."

"What if... I just leave?" Catra pressed, her voice trembling slightly. There was a heavy silence, and Catra felt guilt and uncertainty rise within her. "Sorry, Mom, I didn't mean—"

"I know," her mom interrupted. "I never show it, but I'd hate it if you left," more silence followed, tension thickening the air. Finally, her mom spoke again, her voice tinged with resignation. "You know that the world out there is different. It's scary. Nothing like this town."

"I know," Catra murmured, her gaze fixed on her tea.

"You grew up here, just like your dad. You've been here your whole life. You don't know any better. Any different,"

"But I want to try. I want to know for sure."

Her mom sighed, a mixture of sadness and acceptance in her expression. "I'm not going to stop you," she said quietly. "But you need to really think about this before you jump the gun, okay?"

"Okay,"

"Anyways, I need to go. Have a good sleep, Catra."

Catra nodded, feeling a lump form in her throat. She watched as her mom gathered her things and headed towards the door. When she was alone again, Catra sank to the floor, burying her face in her hands.

The weight of her decision hung heavy around her, but deep down, Catra knew it was something she needed to do. As she sipped her tea, the warmth spreading through her, she closed her eyes and let out a long, slow breath. The road ahead was uncertain and daunting, but for the first time in a long while, Catra felt a glimmer of hope and determination stirring within her.

Catra woke up at 3:23PM. Those midnight shifts were really messing up her sleep schedule. Though, to be honest, what

young adult actually had a good sleep schedule anyways.

Catra groggily reached for her phone as the morning sunlight filtered through her window. Her eyes struggled to focus on the screen as she blinked away sleep. There it was, a good morning text from Adora, and Catra couldn't help but smile despite the grogginess.

ADORA: good morning

She laughed to herself, replying back.

CATRA: morning

ADORA: how did you sleep?

She rolled herself out of bed.

CATRA: great. Tea worked wonders

ADORA: great :)

ADORA: I got that tea from a friend

She smirked to herself, throwing on her closest sweater over her head.

CATRA: don't tell me it's illegal

ADORA: god no

ADORA: it's from the local markets in Glimmer's area

ADORA: so

ADORA: wanna come over?

She poked her head out the window, letting the cool air hit her to jolt her awake. It was still a cold out.

CATRA: yeah sure

ADORA: my mom won't be home for a few hours

She rolled her eyes but smiled to herself. This was the new normal. Where they'd make room and time for each other as much as possible. She slipped into a pair of jeans and her thickest socks before heading downstairs. She scribbled a quick note for her mom—something something errands, something something important—in case she got home from Bonnie's.

The cold hit her like a wall, the crisp air nipping at her exposed skin. She wrapped her arms around herself as she made her way to the fence that separated her backyard from Adora's. The snow crunched under her boots with each step, the sound muffled by the stillness of the morning. She reached the familiar gap in the fence, the one they'd used countless times before, and slipped through it effortlessly.

The door was unlocked, as usual, and Catra let herself in, heading straight to Adora's room. Adora was sitting on her bed, looking cozy and content, and Catra couldn't help but smile at the sight of her.

"Hey," Catra replied, a grin spreading across her face. She shrugged off her coat and kicked off her boots, making her way to the bed. She climbed in next to Adora, feeling the warmth of the blanket envelop her as she snuggled in close.

"Hey," Adora replied with a snuggle into Catra's shoulder.

Catra took a deep breath. She nestled deeper into the blanket, feeling the gentle rise and fall of Adora's breathing. The silence was soothing, but there was something she needed to say,

something that had been on her mind since their last conversation.

"Adora," Catra began, her voice barely above a whisper.

"Yeah?" Adora turned to look at her, concern flickering in her eyes.

Catra hesitated, searching for the right words. "I've been thinking a lot since we talked last time. About... everything."

“...yeah?”

“You know, with my mom and this town…” Catra said, her voice growing steadier. "About how everything always feels the same. Maybe a little claustrophobic.”

“Is everything okay?”

Catra nodded. “I’ve just been thinking…maybe I need a change.”

“What?”

“You know I might,” she gulped. “Leave this town. Join you at your—”

Adora's reaction was immediate and intense. "WHAT? WAIT, WAIT."

“—college,” she couldn’t even finish her words. Catra laughed.

Adora lunged over at her, trapping her in a tight squeeze. “ARE YOU SERIOUS?!”

Catra chuckled softly at Adora's response. “Stop freaking out you loser."

“I just can’t believe it! Oh my god I need to show you all the best places to eat around campus. Oh and this super cool spot I know near the lake. And—!”

“There’s a bunch of stuff I need to do, including actually transferring my classes over from my online degree,”

“We’ll figure it out,” she scooped Catra’s hands into her own. “What made you change your mind suddenly?”

Catra shrugged, suddenly feeling self-conscious. "It's been on my mind for a while, I guess. Especially after our conversation yesterday."

Adora nodded slowly, processing the information. "You mean about leaving this town?"

"Yeah," Catra confirmed, her voice steady. "I just... I feel stuck here sometimes, you know?"

Adora reached out and took Catra's hand in hers, squeezing gently. "I get it," she said softly. "But leaving is a big step. You don't have to, like, force yourself or anything."

Catra nodded, her gaze dropping to their intertwined fingers. "I know."

Adora leaned closer, her forehead resting against Catra's. "You don't have to decide right now," she murmured. "I just don’t want you leaving because you feel pressured to. Just know that whatever you decide, I'll support you."

Catra closed her eyes, feeling a wave of gratitude wash over her. "Thank you, Adora," she whispered. "For everything."

They sat there in silence for a moment, the weight of Catra's decision hanging between them. But in that moment, with Adora

by her side, Catra felt a glimmer of hope and possibility for the future. Whatever path she chose, she knew she wouldn't be facing it alone.

Chapter 13

Chapter Notes

Two chapters in one week??? No wayyyyyy

Adora woke up to the familiar chill of a winter morning, the frost creeping up the edges of her window. She was getting used to mornings like this—cold, quiet, and wrapped in a blanket of snow that seemed to muffle the entire world. She stretched, the warmth of her bed reluctant to let her go, but she pushed herself up and swung her feet onto the icy floor.

Pulling on a thick sweater and her favourite woollen socks (which she recently bought with Catra at the mall), Adora padded down the stairs. The house was still, the early hour ensuring that most of her family was still in bed. She took a deep breath, the crispness of the morning air invigorating her as she made her way to the kitchen.

To her surprise, her dad was already there. Usually, he was holed up in his study. But today, he was seated at the dining table, a steaming cup of coffee in his hands and a stack of papers spread out before him. He looked up as she entered, his eyes briefly meeting hers before returning to his work.

Their relationship had been weird recently. Growing up, they were best buds. He used to be her biggest supporter. Every competition? He was there. Every spelling bee? He was there. But something changed a few years ago. He became emotionally distant, retreating into his work and his study, leaving her puzzled and alone. At first, she had assumed it was just because she was

getting busier, but as time went on and she moved on to college, the distance between them had only grown.

Today, though, he was here, and she was determined to make the most of it. As he stood to leave the table, she called out, "Dad, wait.” he stopped. “Can we just sit together for a sec?”

He looked a little taken aback, but shrugged. “Sure. There’s a bit more coffee left in the pot.”

Adora grabbed the pot and a mug, and swiftly topped up her dad’s.

"So," Adora began, searching for the right words, "I feel like we haven't really talked in a while."

Her dad nodded slowly. "Yeah, it's been a while. You've been busy with college and all."

"And you've been busy with work," she added gently. “How has work been?”

"Yeah, it’s fine," he said, shrugging slightly. "I’m just working mostly remotely now."

Another silence settled between them, the steam from their mugs swirling up into the air. Adora watched her dad for a moment, noting the lines on his face that seemed deeper than she remembered, the weariness in his eyes.

"How's college?" he asked, breaking the silence.

"Yeah, it's actually really good, Dad," Adora replied, a genuine smile spreading across her face. "You should visit sometime."

The truth was, neither one of her parents even bothered to come once. Not even for orientation. She took herself to orientation. She unboxed everything herself. She organised everything herself. And not once, did her parents even offer to help or show any sign of interest.

She wanted her dad to apologise. She wanted him to tell her how much he wanted to go. And that he’s so glad she brought it up.

But he said nothing. He took a long sip of his coffee. One that was painfully too long.

“Do you guys not care? ”she asked, her voice tinged with hurt.

"Adora, we do care," he said, his tone earnest.

“Do you like, hate me or something?” she said, trying to make it sound like a joke but failing to mask the seriousness.

“Of course not,”

"Then why does mom seem to hate me?" Adora asked, the question hanging heavy in the air.

"Your mom doesn’t hate you," he said, his voice gentle but firm.

"It feels like it sometimes," Adora said, looking down at her coffee. “She's always criticising me, always pointing out what I'm doing wrong. I feel like I can’t do anything right by her.”

Her dad sighed, taking another sip of his coffee. "Sometimes it feels like she hates me too," he admitted with a small chuckle, the first time he'd laughed all holiday. "You know she just likes things to be a certain way."

"Yeah, she’s a perfectionist and she cares about appearances a lot. She always has," Adora said, a hint of frustration in her voice.

"Yep, that’s your mother for you," he agreed. "It doesn’t mean she doesn’t love you; she just gets misguided sometimes."

"I sometimes think she'll hate me more the less I fit into her image of what she wants," Adora confessed, her voice barely above a whisper. "I mean, the first step was going to college, right?"

"Right," he said, looking at her with a knowing but non-pressing look. "I wouldn't care, you know?" he added after a moment of silence. "I wouldn't care if you went against everything she wanted, as long as you're happy."

"I know," Adora replied. "...wait, you're talking about college, right?"

"I'm talking about anything," he clarified. "As long as you're happy, you can do whatever you want."

"Thanks, Dad."

With that, he left. Though his presence seemed to linger in Adora's mind a little longer.

Adora was working at the dining table, her fingers typing away on her laptop. The winter sunlight streamed through the windows, casting a warm glow on the table cluttered with papers and her coffee mug.

She was deep in concentration when she heard the front door open and her mom's familiar footsteps echoed through the hallway. Her mom entered the dining room, carrying several shopping bags.

"Adora, help me put this away," her mom said, her tone brisk but not unkind.

"Sure," Adora replied, closing her laptop and standing up to assist her mom.

As they began unpacking the groceries, her mom glanced at her with a raised eyebrow. "Hope you haven't spent all day lounging around."

Adora sighed inwardly. "I've been trying to sort out some uni admin things for next semester."

"Oh? Like what?" her mom asked, placing a carton of milk in the fridge.

Adora hesitated for a moment before answering. "Catra might transfer to my university," h er mom froze mid-motion, a can of beans in her hand. "So I just thought I'd help out since the process is difficult," Adora continued, trying to keep her tone neutral.

Her mom set the can down and looked at her with a hint of exasperation. "She's really stuck to your hip, isn't she? She can't do anything for herself?"

"What? It's not like that. It's just really difficult, and I wanted to help," Adora defended, her frustration bubbling up. “I don’t think you get it mom. Uni admin is difficult to figure out! Like when Glimmer had to change her major and—”

"But Catra has always been like this, Adora. She uses you and expects you to do so much for her," her mom said, her voice tinged with disapproval.

"That's not true," Adora shot back, her eyes narrowing.

"Why does she spend so much time with you?"

"Because she's my friend?" Adora replied, her voice rising in disbelief. “What kind of question is that?”

"You spend everyday with her. A little excessive, don’t you think?"

“What? Mom, what are you actually complaining about? We spent yesterday together,” Adora lowered the milk in her hand.

“That’s different. I’m your mother,” she finished the last of her pile. “You spend so much time with Catra to the point where its abnormal.”

Adora shoved her half empty bag of groceries. “Why don’t you like her? You used to love Catra. She used to stay over every night when we were kids and you never had an issue with her.”

Her mom didn’t meet Adora’s eyes, instead, choosing to take Adora’s bag and continue packing away the groceries like nothing happened. “She grew up and changed. She *was* a sweet little girl. Then her dad left and got her piercings and grew out her raggedy hair and started wearing these alternative clothes and,” she groaned into her hands. “Does she have any tattoos? She seems like the type.”

“No mom,” and Adora was sure of that. *On any part of her body. She’s checked. Thoroughly.* “So you hate her because her dad left? As if she had any choice in that?”

“It’s not exactly that—”

“Then what is it mom?” she pleaded. “She’s my best friend and I want you to like her.”

Her mom stopped and her eyes seemed to fall shut. That's the first sign something was wrong. Her mom never fell silent, not like this. When she halts and scrunches up her hands into fists, that's when you know she's serious. She screams, she shouts, but when it's serious, she gives it a second. Adora couldn't muster up a word, almost slipping into her child-attributed role of shutting her mouth and waiting until her mom told her off.

"I saw you," she simply said. Her mom cupped her hands in front of her, but Adora could spot that she was digging her nails into the back of her hands.

"What?"

"I saw you with her,"

"What? When?"

"The day you left for college," the colour left her face. Adora went numb. "After you packed your bags and loaded them into your car, and your father and I went back into the house…I saw Catra come over to our house before you drove off."

"Oh God," she brought her hand to her mouth, not knowing whether she was actually going to puke. "Mom that—"

"I don't need her doing that to you,"

“What? She wasn’t the one who—”

“She assaulted you,”

“Mom,” she sputtered. “What are you on about?”

“I saw her. She assaulted you. What else could that be?”

“I-I,”

“How am I supposed to like Catra after that? After what she did to you,”

“ *I* kissed her,”

Her mom gave a shaky and pained, “What?”

“I…” Adora couldn’t say it again. *Just say it. I kissed her. I kissed her. I—*

“What happened to you?” her eyes were harsh. Her gaze cut right through her. “What did I do…wrong…?”

“You didn’t do anything. I’m just—”

“But you’re my little girl,”

“Am I not…anymore?”

She hesitated. Then the moment passed. And she was still silent.

Tears welled beneath her eyes. “Do you not…love me?”

“Adora,”

She bit down on her bottom lip. “I see how it is.”

“Adora, wait.”

Adora's heart pounded in her chest as she rushed upstairs. She grabbed a bag and started stuffing it with clothes and essentials, her movements frantic and desperate. Tears blurred her vision,

but she didn't care. She needed to get out. She needed to breathe.

Her mom's voice echoed through the stairs, but Adora blocked it out. She couldn't deal with it right now. She needed to escape.

Once her bag was packed, she raced downstairs and out the door, her mom's confused and hurt calls following her. She didn't look back. She couldn't.

Adora jumped into her car, hands trembling as she started the engine. She drove off, the tires screeching on the pavement. She didn't know where she was going, but anywhere was better than here.

She found herself parked outside Catra's house. She took a deep breath, trying to steady her nerves before getting out of the car. She walked up to the door and knocked.

Catra opened the door, looking exhausted from her shift. She was still in her work uniform. "Hey," she said, her voice laced with concern. "Is everything okay?"

Adora shook her head, tears still streaming down her face. "I'm going to my parents' lakehouse. Wanna come?"

Catra's brow furrowed in confusion. "Well, if we get back by the 3rd of Jan for work, I guess."

"Yeah, sure," Adora said, her voice shaky.

Catra nodded and went inside to grab a few things. Adora waited, trying to compose herself. When Catra returned, she had a small bag slung over her shoulder.

They sat in the car for a moment, the silence heavy. Catra reached out and wiped a tear from Adora's cheek.

"Do you wanna talk about it?" she asked softly.

"My mom knows about us," Adora said, her voice breaking. "She’s known since the day I left for college."

"Oh..." Catra's eyes widened in shock. "Is that why we're running away from our problems?"

"I'm not running," Adora insisted, her voice trembling. "I'm just getting away for a few days. That's all." She grabbed Catra's hand, squeezing it tightly. "Seriously. I promise I'm coming back to face them."

Catra looked at her for a long moment before nodding. "I'll be there with you for every bit of it."

Adora felt a surge of relief at Catra's words. They drove off into the night, leaving behind the confusion and hurt for a few days of peace and clarity.

Chapter 14

The drive to the lakehouse was long and winding, the kind that twisted through dense woods and over gentle hills. It wasn't in the direction of her college, but instead, the complete opposite direction into richer, denser environments and nature. As they neared their destination, Adora could see the familiar landmarks that marked the path to her family's old retreat. The air grew crisper, filled with the scent of pine and fresh water.

Adora's mouth parted in awe. "We haven't been here since—"

"4 years ago," Catra finished for her.

Finally, the lakehouse came into view, standing tall and proud despite its age. It was a grand structure, made entirely of dark wood that had weathered over the years but still retained a certain elegance. Large windows overlooked the lake, their glass panes reflecting the usually serene waters (though now they were completely frozen over). The front porch, wide and inviting, stretched across the front of the house, complete with a pair of rocking chairs.

As they pulled up, memories flooded back to Adora. She remembered the summers spent here, both families together. Their dads would grill burgers on the deck while their moms laughed over lemonade. She and Catra would run around the large yard, their laughter echoing across the lake. They used to swing from the old rope tied to the sturdy oak tree by the shore, plunging into the cool water with delighted screams. Sometimes, they'd take the little boat out, paddling into the middle of the lake,

feeling as if they were the only two people in the world. That was her favourite part.

But now, the place felt different. The lively energy had faded, replaced by a quiet stillness. The lakehouse had been virtually abandoned since Catra's dad left. The once well-kept lawn was now overgrown, and the swing hung motionless, the rope frayed and worn.

Adora parked the car, and she and Catra got out, stretching their legs after the long drive. They grabbed their bags from the trunk and made their way up the creaky wooden steps. Adora pushed open the front door, the familiar scent of cedar and old memories hitting her immediately.

The interior was as grand as she remembered. The large kitchen, with its wooden countertops and rustic cabinets, opened into a spacious living area. A massive stone fireplace dominated one wall, with a scattering of comfy armchairs and a well-worn couch facing it.

Adora and Catra walked in, the floorboards creaking under their feet. They set their bags down in the living room, taking a moment to soak in the atmosphere.

"It's just like I remember," Catra said, her voice soft with nostalgia.

"Yeah," Adora replied, looking around. "Feels like a lifetime ago."

They stood there for a moment, lost in their memories, before Catra broke the silence. "Let's get settled in. Then we can figure out what to do next."

Adora and Catra hurried upstairs, briefly contemplating whether they should jokingly take their old bunk beds for old time's sake before settling for the master bedroom that Adora's parents used to take.

Catra pulled out a sweater and folded it aside. "So…what made you run away to here of all places?" she asked, her tone gentle but curious.

Adora paused, placing a folded blanket down. "Because it was a nice change of pace," she replied, looking around the room. "Plus, it feels like we finally get our own little place for a bit, y'know?

"Yeah but, your parent's lakehouse?"

"I mean, it's the only place that's kinda close-ish to here and we haven't been here for years so,"

"Yeah…" Catra's mind let itself wander a bit. *Not since my dad left* . She sighed. "You know it's New Year's coming up, right?"

"I know," Adora said, smiling faintly.

"You're not going home?" Catra asked, raising an eyebrow. "You know, spend it with them?"

Adora sighed, shaking her head. "I don't want to, but if you want to go home, you can. I can drive back."

"Eh, New Year's is kinda boring," Catra shrugged. "My mom's gonna hang with the neighbourhood moms and play poker at Danny's house."

Adora laughed, a hint of relief in her voice. "Oh yeah, forgot she does that every year."

"Well, I mean, I somehow always ended up at yours during New Year's anyway, right?" Catra said, her eyes lighting up with the memory.

When Adora closed her eyes, she could picture it. Her parents taking the two of them down to the centennial park where all the neighbourhood families would come out to watch the fireworks. Picnic mats would be sprawled over the dewy ground. Everyone would be wrapped up in their winter coats and scarves. Then, they would go home for hot cocoa.

Adora's smile grew wider. "So, we get to do that again, right? But just the two of us this time?"

"Yeah," Catra agreed, a warmth spreading between them as they shared the familiar tradition. "Hopefully we can see fireworks here."

“I don’t know how much we can see but imagine how nice it would be to sit by the lake,”

“Hopefully we don’t fall in,”

“Well it’s frozen over at this time of year anyways,”

“That’s probably why we only ever came here during the summer.”

Adora reached for wooden cabinets, opening the top draw before she paused.

Catra peered over her shoulder. “What is it?”

Adora pursed her lips, then gave a sigh. “It’s my mom’s old jewellery,” she fished out a platinum necklace adorned with a bright aquamarine stone. “She hasn’t worn this in years.”

“It’s pretty,” she offered a small compliment. "Why'd she leave it here?"

"She probably thought we'd come back more often..." she breathed out. “She said she’d give it to me when I graduated high school. Guess she’s just left it here.”

“I mean, you’ve graduated high school now,” Catra smirked. “I say take it.”

“I don’t know. It feels like stealing,”

“At least try putting it on,” Catra gently took it in her hands, then wrapped it around Adora’s neck to clip it. “Boom. How do you feel?”

Adora turned to the mirror placed next to the door. She couldn’t help but to smile a little.

“It looks nice,” her girlfriend slipped a hand onto her waist.

But her grin seemed to fade a little. “I look like my mom.”

“Well the necklace brings out the blue in your eyes. And I guess your mom has blue eyes?”

“Her old photos of when she was younger,” Adora turned to face her. “I look just like that.”

“Maybe, but you’re nothing like her,” she placed her hands onto her shoulders. “You’re kind, you’re brave, you’re easily the smartest person I know,” Adora chuckled a little. “You’re passionate, you’re dedicated, you’re loyal. Do I need to say more?”

“You’re sweet,” she brought their foreheads together. “I’m glad I have you.”

They spent the rest of the day finally settling into their environment. They stopped at a small grocery store about 15 minutes away (which was the closest bit of civilization they had to where they were staying) to pick up essentials. It was enough to fill their entire kitchen counter with fresh vegetables, pasta and snacks. Catra quickly got to cooking.

Around 5PM, in the pitch darkness, Adora Gray, being the absolute genius that she is, decided to go out to retrieve firewood from outside. Though when she stepped outside, she really regretted it. But she was too stubborn to go back.

The ground crunched under her boots, a mixture of frost and old leaves. The lake nearby was a solid sheet of ice, reflecting the pale winter sky. It was a stark contrast to the vibrant, green summers she remembered, but it had its own quiet beauty.

Inside the woodshed, she found neatly stacked logs and kindling. She gathered enough wood to keep the fire going for the night, balancing them in her arms as she made her way back to the house. The smell of cooking hit her as soon as she stepped inside, a comforting blend of garlic and herbs.

Catra was busy at the stove, stirring a pan with practised ease. "Dinner's almost ready," she called over her shoulder. "Just need a few more minutes.

Adora set the firewood down by the fireplace, arranging the logs and kindling with care. She struck a match, lighting the kindling and watching as the flames began to grow, crackling warmly. The firelight filled the room, casting flickering shadows and adding a cozy glow to the wooden interior.

They eventually sat on the dining table that was unfamiliarly empty. Funnily enough, they accidentally ended up taking their old seats which were right next to each other and facing the fireplace.

“You’re such a good cook,” Adora said, digging in.

“Eh it was pretty easy,” she shrugged off. “Just some garlic, a mix of dried and fresh herbs, a splash of cream, and lots of parmesan. Oh, and a bit of lemon zest for brightness. The trick is to let the garlic cook slowly so it doesn't burn, then add the cream and cheese. Once the pasta's done, we just toss it all together and it's good to go.”

“I think you found your calling," she joked. "Maybe you should open a restaurant."

Catra laughed, shaking her head. "I don't know about that. I just cook a lot at home since Mom's always busy. It's kind of become my thing."

"Well, you're really good at it," Adora said, her tone sincere. "I can't cook to save my life. I usually just survive on instant noodles and takeout."

“Eh, with me around you’ll never need to cook. As long as you become ultra rich and I can be a stay at home mom,”

“Oh? So we’re going to be parents?”

“You don’t want kids?”

“I do,”

“How many?”

“Two,”

“Good answer,”

“I mean we’re both only childs do we know how lonely it gets,”

“Yeah well we had each other though, so we’re lucky in that sense,” Catra swallowed down a mouthful. “So, let’s talk ideal home.”

“Hmm, I’ve lived with roommates for like a year now and I like them but I’d eventually like a place of our own. The apartment life isn’t too bad but I know that real-life apartments suck way more so...”

“In what way?”

“Mmm bad neighbours. Paying for strata,”

“So you’d rather buy a house?”

“If the economy allows,” she joked. “Not too big though.”

“Right?! I don’t want to clean *that* much,”

After they finished dinner, Adora insisted on handling the cleanup. Catra didn't protest, leaning back against the kitchen island with a contented sigh. She watched Adora move around the kitchen, the light from the fireplace casting a warm glow on her face. There was a quiet intimacy in the moment, a sense of easy familiarity that felt like a natural extension of their day.

As Adora washed the dishes, her hands moving methodically under the stream of water, Catra couldn't help but smile. "Man, it would be nice if we could do this more often," she mused aloud, her voice soft but carrying a weight of unspoken longing.

Adora glanced over her shoulder, her eyes meeting Catra's. "Well, it'll be like this for four days at least, right?" she replied with a playful smile.

"Yeah," Catra agreed, her gaze lingering on Adora. "But I want this to be my forever."

Adora paused, a dish still in her hand, and turned to face Catra fully. "Wow, are you proposing after the first date?" she teased,

her tone light but her eyes searching.

Catra snickered, a blush creeping up her cheeks. "Maybe I am," she said, half-joking, half-serious. "But really, Adora... doesn't this just feel right?"

Adora set the dish down, drying her hands on a towel as she walked over to Catra. She leaned against the island, her eyes thoughtful. "Yeah, it does," she admitted. "It's just... easy, you know? Being with you like this. It feels like everything else just fades away."

Catra nodded, a soft smile playing on her lips. "Exactly," she said, reaching out to touch Adora's hand. "No stress, no expectations. Just us, being ourselves."

Adora squeezed her hand gently, feeling a swell of emotion. "I want this too," she said, her voice quiet but firm. "Maybe not all the time, but... I could get used to this."

Catra's smile widened, her eyes bright with emotion. "So, we're on the same page, then?"

Adora nodded, a smile spreading across her face. "Yeah," she said softly. "We're on the same page."

Catra stepped closer, her eyes never leaving Adora's. The world seemed to shrink until it was just the two of them, wrapped in the cozy embrace of the lakehouse. Without a word, Catra reached out and gently took Adora's hand. With a gentle tug, she pulled Adora closer. Slowly, they began to sway, their movements perfectly in sync. There was no music, just the rhythm of their breaths and the silent melody of their hearts beating in unison. The firelight flickered, casting playful shadows on the walls as they danced.

Adora rested her head on Catra's shoulder, feeling the warmth of her skin and the steady rise and fall of her breath. She closed her eyes, losing herself in the moment. Catra's hand on her back was reassuring, guiding her with a gentle firmness that made her feel safe.

Catra pulled back slightly, just enough to look into Adora's eyes. Her gaze was soft, filled with an emotion that made Adora's heart skip a beat. Slowly, almost tentatively, Catra leaned in. Adora met her halfway, their lips brushing in a gentle, lingering kiss.

The kiss deepened, filled with unspoken promises and the shared understanding that had always existed between them. It was sweet and tender, a reaffirmation of everything they had always known but had only recently begun to acknowledge.

When they finally pulled apart, Catra's forehead rested against Adora's, their breaths mingling in the cool air. The world seemed to hold its breath, the fire crackling softly in the background.

Finally, Catra broke the silence with a soft laugh. "Well, I guess we should finish up here," she said, gesturing to the remaining dishes.

Adora chuckled, shaking her head. "Yeah, let's do that," she agreed, turning back to the sink. "But just so you know, I'm keeping you to that proposal," she added, throwing a playful glance over her shoulder.

Catra's laughter echoed through the kitchen, light and carefree. "Deal," she said, her voice filled with warmth and affection. "It's a deal."

Chapter 15

Catra woke up to the soft morning light filtering through the curtains of the master bedroom. When she rubbed sleep out of her eyes, she took note of everything in the room. Wooden beams across the ceiling. Nature-themed artwork on the walls. Forest-green curtains that matched the quilted blanket. This wasn't her room.

Oh shit . *That's right.* She ran away with Adora to her parent's lakehouse.

Adora. *Adora.* She patted the spot next to her and found it completely empty. Just as Catra's heart began to race, the door creaked open, and Adora stepped in, a steaming mug of tea in her hand.

"Hey, you're awake," Adora said with a soft smile, walking over to the bed. "I made you some tea."

Catra exhaled a shaky breath, her panic slowly subsiding. "Sorry, sorry, I just—" She trailed off, feeling foolish for her reaction. "Thanks for the tea."

"Are you okay?" genuine concern ran over her face as she passed the tea over.

“Yeah, sorry, I’m being stupid,” she brushed her hand through her hair.

“Bad dream?”

“Ha, yeah you could say that,” *it’s the same one she’s had periodically. But Adora wouldn’t be ready for the conversation.*

“Well, we can just chill in bed a bit longer if you want,”

Catra nodded, taking the mug in her hands, the warmth of the tea soothing her nerves. They settled back into the bed, leaning against the headboard with the quilt pulled up over their laps.

“That was a good night,” Adora said, breaking the comfortable silence. She reached over and brushed a strand of hair away from Catra’s face.

“Yeah, it was,” Catra agreed, taking a sip of her tea. “It’s nice to wake up here. Feels like a different world.”

Adora smiled, her eyes reflecting the warmth of the morning sun. “So, what do you want to do today?”

Catra thought for a moment, her mind drifting through possibilities. “I don’t know. Maybe explore a bit? See if we can find some of our old spots.”

Adora nodded. “That sounds fun. We could take the boat out if the lake isn’t too frozen. Or we could just go for a hike, see how everything’s changed.”

Catra leaned back against the pillows. “Hike sounds nice.”

She hummed, taking a sip of her tea. “Hike it is.”

They eventually got out of bed and went downstairs. Catra took charge of breakfast, whipping up a classic set of eggs and bacon while Adora set the table. They felt like a classic married couple, they just needed a newspaper and a cute apron at this point. And once that was all digested, they cleaned up and got their shoes on, ready for an impromptu hike on a trail they hadn't gone on for years. Nothing could go wrong, right?

Adora led the way, guiding them to a trail near the house that her dad used to take them on. Large flat rocks made a steep staircase up a hill. The trail was still beautiful, though overgrown in places. Birds chirped in the trees, and the sound of leaves rustling in the gentle breeze filled the air. Adora and Catra walked side by side, their hands occasionally brushing against each other.

And as they dodged bushes, Catra's thoughts wandered for a moment.

"Hey Adora," she spoke up suddenly.

"Yeah, what's up?"

"Does your dad go on hikes a lot?"

She shrugged. "Not really. I don't think I've seen him do a single physical activity to be honest. Though, he did seem to love taking us on this particular hiking trail for some reason."

Just like she remembered, Adora's dad would always propose these random impromptu hikes. Like, no set up whatsoever. They would be in the middle of a barbecue and suddenly— *girls, let's go for a hike!* Or that time they were trying to get some summer reading and boom *—it's hike time girls!*

Though now that it's been years and she's much older than she was back then, she started to realise that those exclaims were conveniently placed whenever her parents began bickering. She wondered for a second whether Adora's dad was taking them on walks while her parents were shouting at each other back at the lakehouse. And she also wondered whether she was stupid for missing the signs.

They continued along the trail, enjoying the serenity of the forest. After a while, they came to a small clearing with a waterfall cascading down into a crystal-clear pool. The sight was breathtaking, the water sparkling in the sunlight.

They sat down on a large rock by the edge of the pool, the sound of the waterfall creating a soothing background. Adora took Catra's hand in hers, their fingers intertwining.

“This place is magical,” Catra said, her voice filled with awe.

Adora nodded. “Yeah, it really is.”

They sat there in comfortable silence, the beauty of the place enveloping them. Catra leaned her head on Adora’s shoulder, feeling a deep sense of contentment.

"You know what waterfalls symbolise, right?" Adora spoke.

"Nope. What?"

"Well, it differs across cultures. Chinese art uses it as symbolism for a flow of wealth, prosperity and good fortune. In Japan it can symbolise cleansing of the soul. But I guess for us, the most applicable interpretation is healing," she squeezed her hand. "And strength."

"...Is this what you do in college?"

"History of shared cultural experiences. It was one of my electives this sem," she smiled. "But that's not the point; I'm glad you said hiking because I thought it was a nice little time to reflect."

Catra hummed. "Well, it's been a bit of a blur recently. Ever since you rocked up at my house after my midnight shift asking whether I can run away with you to a lakehouse for a few days...I feel like we haven't actually talked about the issue at hand here."

"Yeah, I just needed the fresh air to straighten me out I guess. I just didn't really expect my mom to know about us..."

"Yeah, but it kinda makes sense now, right? It explains the way she was treating you,"

"She's always been a bit off about some stuff, it's just gotten worse after...you know,"

"Us?"

"Yeah us,"

There was a second of silence. Catra kicked a rock by her feet. "What do you wanna do?"

"After New Years I should go back. Actually talk to her properly. I guess I should "officially come out" or something at least. I'm dreading it though,"

"Do you want me to be there?"

"I love your support but I think I have to handle this one on my own,"

"Fair enough. Call me if you need a way out again," she got up from her feet, offering a hand out for Adora to take. "We can just spend another week at this lakehouse. I wouldn't mind."

It was about 11:30PM. They laid together in the master bedroom, curtains closed.

It's that dream — Catra thought. God not that dream.

It always started with her standing alone in a dimly lit room, shadows flickering and dancing on the walls. The air was thick and oppressive, each breath feeling like a struggle. She called out for Adora, but her voice echoed back to her, empty and hollow.

The room shifted around her, walls elongating and stretching until they were impossibly high, the ceiling disappearing into a void. Suddenly, she was outside Adora’s driveway. Except it was strangely so long and led to the middle of nowhere. And Adora would be packing her last bag into her car.

“Adora!” Catra shouted out to her but her voice never got to her. Adora would just load herself into her car and keep driving off. The sky would turn a deep, unnatural red. The ground beneath her feet was uneven and cracked, like a parched desert.

In the distance, she saw Adora, but she seemed far away, almost out of reach. Catra tried to run towards her, but her feet felt like they were sinking into the ground, the earth pulling her back with every step. She shouted Adora's name, but the words were swallowed by the heavy air.

Adora turned to look at her, her face a mask of sorrow and regret. She reached out a hand, but before Catra could grasp it, Adora began to fade, her form becoming transparent and ghostly. The more Catra struggled to reach her, the faster Adora vanished, like smoke dissipating into the wind.

Catra's surroundings morphed again, the field transforming into a dark, endless hallway. She could hear distant whispers, unintelligible and sinister, growing louder and more insistent. The walls of the hallway were lined with doors, each one slamming shut as she approached, the noise echoing in the oppressive silence.

At the end of the hallway, she saw Adora one last time, standing by a door that seemed to glow with a faint, ethereal light. Desperation clawed at Catra's chest as she pushed forward, but the ground beneath her became a tar-like substance, slowing her movements to a crawl.

Adora looked back at her, tears streaming down her face, and mouthed the words, "I'm sorry." Before Catra could respond, the door opened, and Adora stepped through, disappearing into the blinding light beyond.

Catra screamed, a heart-wrenching cry of loss and anguish, but the door slammed shut with a final, resounding thud. The light flickered out, leaving her in complete darkness. She was alone, utterly and completely, with only the echo of Adora's sorrowful gaze haunting her.

She jolted awake, her heart racing and her body drenched in sweat. The nightmare's lingering terror clung to her, making it hard to breathe. She looked around the room, her eyes wide and panicked, until they landed on Adora, who was already stirring, awakened by Catra's sudden movement.

Adora, groggy but alert, immediately reached out to her.

“Catra, hey, it’s okay. I’m here,” she whispered, her voice soothing and calm. She gently placed a hand on Catra’s shoulder, feeling the tension in her muscles.

Catra's eyes darted around the room, unfocused and wild. She looked at Adora, tears brimming in her eyes. "Adora?"

"Hey, hey," she ran her hand up and down her arm. "It's okay. I'm here."

Her mind felt cloudy, sleep and terror combating each other in her brain. "Don't leave me, please. Please don't leave me again," she pleaded, her voice breaking with each word. "You can't. You just can't."

Adora's heart ached at the sight of her. She took a deep breath, trying to remain composed. "I'm not going anywhere, Catra. I promise," she said softly, wrapping her arms around her. "I'm right here."

Catra clung to her, her body trembling. "Promise me," she whispered, her voice filled with desperation. "Promise you won't leave."

"I promise," Adora repeated, feeling a lump form in her throat. She held Catra tightly, her hand gently stroking her back in slow, calming motions. She could feel Catra's heartbeat gradually slowing down, her breaths becoming less ragged.

As Catra's grip on her began to loosen and her breathing evened out, Adora felt an overwhelming wave of guilt wash over her. She had been the cause of Catra's distress, the one who had left and made her feel abandoned. The memory of that painful departure haunted her, and now, seeing Catra so broken by the fear of losing her again, it was almost too much to bear.

Adora's mind raced with conflicting emotions. She wanted to reassure Catra, to tell her that everything would be okay, but the guilt gnawed at her. She had left before, and despite her best intentions, the fear that she might hurt Catra again lingered at the back of her mind. How could she make such a promise when she herself was unsure of what the future held?

As Catra slowly drifted back to sleep, her body relaxed and her grip on Adora loosened. Adora held her close, feeling the steady rise and fall of her breathing. She kissed the top of Catra's head, her heart heavy with emotion. She whispered softly, "I'm here. I'm not going anywhere."

But sleep eluded Adora. She lay there, staring at the ceiling, her thoughts racing. She felt the weight of her promise and the responsibility that came with it. She wanted to protect Catra, to be her safe haven, but the fear of failing her gnawed at her insides.

Adora listened to the rhythmic sound of Catra's breathing, feeling the warmth of her body against her own. She replayed the nightmare in her mind, the image of Catra's desperate plea etched deeply into her heart. She knew she had to be strong for Catra, to reassure her that their bond was unbreakable.

The first light of dawn began to filter through the window, casting a soft glow in the room. Adora gently extricated herself from Catra's embrace, careful not to wake her. She sat on the edge of the bed, her mind heavy with thoughts. The promise she had made to Catra weighed on her. She had no idea whether she could actually keep it.

Chapter 16

Chapter Notes

> I've been super swamped with my IRL life so I could only muster up something short. Sorry!

New Years. The first one they’re spending truly alone.

The path to the lake was familiar, but now it felt different—imbued with a sense of nostalgia and the weight of the present moment.

“Remember how we used to run down this path?” Adora said, breaking the silence. Her voice was soft, tinged with nostalgia.

“Yeah,” Catra replied, smiling. “We’d race to see who could get to the water first. You always won, though.”

Adora chuckled. “I think you let me win most of the time.”

“Maybe,” Catra said, bumping her shoulder playfully against Adora’s.

They reached the edge of the lake, where a small wooden dock extended over the water. It creaked under their weight as they walked to the end, the gentle lapping of the water against the wood creating a soothing rhythm. They sat down, their feet

dangling above the water, and gazed out at the horizon where the last rays of the sun were slowly disappearing.

"I love this place. It feels like time stands still here."

As the sky darkened, the stars began to appear, twinkling like diamonds against the deep blue canvas. The temperature dropped slightly, and Adora pulled out a blanket from her bag, wrapping it around both of them. They snuggled close, sharing warmth and the serene beauty of the night.

After a while, the first fireworks lit up the sky, exploding in brilliant colors and patterns. The sound echoed across the lake, adding to the magic of the moment. Adora and Catra watched in awe, their faces illuminated by the dazzling display above.

"Happy New Year, Catra," Adora whispered, her voice barely audible over the sound of the fireworks.

"Happy New Year, Adora," Catra replied, squeezing her hand.

They sat in silence for a while, enjoying the spectacle. When the fireworks subsided, leaving a trail of smoke and sparkles in the sky, Catra turned to Adora.

"So, what's your New Year's resolution?" Adora asked, her eyes curious and a little mischievous.

Catra thought for a moment, looking out at the now-still lake. “I think…I want to enjoy everything as much as possible. Really see what life has to offer.”

Adora smiled, her eyes softening. “That’s a good one.”

“What about you?” she asked, turning to face her.

Adora took a deep breath, thinking. “I want to stop running away from things. To face my fears and be more open with my feelings. Especially with you.”

The world outside their little bubble seemed distant and unimportant. Eventually, they lay back on the dock, staring up at the sky. The Milky Way stretched above them, a river of stars in the vastness of space. They held hands, feeling the cool breeze and the gentle sway of the dock beneath them.

It’s past midnight. So of course, it was time for their signature midnight talks. About growing old. Being adults. Adulting. Jobs. Old people in general. Complaining about the economy. Stupid politics. Then the housing market. Then imagining what their life would be like if they actually got a house. DIY projects. To dumb DIYs. To that time Glimmer tried to make a shelf and failed. Catra thought it was hilarious.

And before they knew it, they began seeing the inclining of daylight again.

“Crap, we actually stayed up,” Catra laughed.

“We always do this,”

“Do we wanna go in? Actually sleep?”

Adora clasped their hands together. “Maybe just a while longer.”

Chapter 17

The New Year's celebrations were behind them, and the drive back home felt like a return to reality. The snow-covered landscape passed by in a blur as Adora and Catra sat quietly in the car, each lost in their thoughts. The cabin had been a place of warmth, peace, and new beginnings, but now they were headed back to the complexities of their everyday lives.

The sun hung low in the sky, casting long shadows across the road, and the temperature was dropping quickly. After a few hours on the road, they decided to stop at a pit stop diner—a cozy, old-fashioned place with neon signs and a retro vibe. The kind of place that felt like it belonged in another time, with red vinyl booths, checkered floors, and the smell of coffee and grilled food wafting through the air.

They parked the car and walked into the diner, the bell above the door jingling as they entered. The warmth inside was a welcome contrast to the biting cold outside. They took a seat in a booth by the window, the vinyl creaking slightly as they settled in.

A waitress appeared with a smile, handing them laminated menus. "What can I get you two?" she asked, her pen poised over a notepad.

Adora glanced over the menu quickly before deciding. "I'll have the classic burger with a side of sweet potato fries, and a vanilla milkshake, please."

Catra looked up from her menu, nodding. "I'll have the grilled chicken sandwich with avocado and a side of onion rings. And a cherry soda."

The waitress jotted down their orders and disappeared into the kitchen, leaving the two of them alone in their booth. They sat in comfortable silence for a few moments, the sounds of clinking dishes and soft music filling the space around them.

Adora leaned back in the booth, her fingers drumming lightly on the table. Her gaze was fixed out the window, watching the cars pull in and out of the gas station across the way. Finally, she spoke, her voice steady but tinged with resolve.

"When we get back, I'm going to sit my mom down and tell her about us," she said, her eyes still focused outside. "I'm going to tell her that we're dating, and that she has to accept it—or I'm going to cut contact with her completely."

Catra's head snapped up at Adora's words, her heart skipping a beat. "Are you sure you want to do that?" she asked, her voice careful.

Adora turned her gaze back to Catra, her blue eyes steady. "I know. I think I have to, though. I'm really happy with you, Catra. And I'm happy with the direction my life is heading. I don't want to keep hiding this part of my life anymore. If she can't accept us, then…I need to move on."

Catra felt a rush of emotions—pride, love, and concern all at once. She reached across the table and took Adora's hand in hers, giving it a reassuring squeeze. "That makes sense," she said softly, her eyes searching Adora's face. "I just want you to be sure. I know how much she means to you."

Adora nodded, her thumb brushing gently over Catra's knuckles. "She does mean a lot to me. But I need to be true to myself. To us."

Catra looked down at their joined hands, a small smile playing on her lips. "I get that. I'm proud of you, Adora."

The waitress returned with their food, setting the plates and drinks down on the table with a cheerful, "Enjoy your meal!"

As they ate, Catra couldn't help but think about the future. She had spent so much of her life running from things, avoiding decisions, and now she was faced with the reality that she needed to figure out what she wanted.

"What about you?" Adora asked suddenly, breaking Catra's train of thought. "Have you made a decision on what you want to do in the future?"

Catra paused, chewing thoughtfully before answering. "Not really," she admitted, setting down her sandwich. "I told my mom I was thinking about leaving, and I kind of want to stick to that."

Adora smiled slightly, her eyes filled with curiosity. “Yeah?”

“Yeah,” Catra nodded. “I have a bit in savings, but I still have to sort a few things out. Like where I’m going to stay.”

Adora’s face brightened with an idea. “My dorm’s lease ends in a few weeks. We can move out together.”

Catra looked at her, eyebrows raised. “Can we handle that?”

Adora chuckled, squeezing Catra’s hand gently. “We practically stayed over at each other’s houses every week when we were little. I think we can manage.”

Catra tilted her head, a hint of concern in her eyes. “Don’t you think we’re moving too fast?”

Adora laughed, her eyes sparkling with mischief. “That’s what we call U-haul lesbians.”

“What?” Catra asked, confused.

“It’s a term,” Adora explained with a grin. “Oh, also, we can apply for housing help through the university. I have a friend who applied for it, and it’s tough, but I can help you with the process.”

Catra’s expression softened, a small smile tugging at the corners of her mouth. “Yeah?”

“Of course,” Adora said earnestly, her gaze steady and reassuring.

Catra took a deep breath, her mind spinning with possibilities. “Well, I’m definitely thinking about it. I want to be a vet. Who knows though, given my grades…”

Adora’s eyebrows raised in curiosity. “In high school or college?”

“High school,” Catra replied, her tone a bit more relaxed. “College hasn’t been too bad.”

Adora laughed, her voice light and teasing. “Well, as long as you’re not doing math, I’m sure you’ll be fine.”

“Luckily, I’m not,” Catra said with a relieved smile.

They both fell into a comfortable silence, the weight of their conversation giving way to a lighter atmosphere. As they finished

their meal, the connection between them felt stronger, as if they had crossed another threshold in their relationship.

With their hands still intertwined, they paid for their meal and made their way back to the car. The sun had set, casting a dusky glow over the landscape as they drove back toward town. The roads were quiet, and the world seemed to shrink to just the two of them, enclosed in the warmth of their car.

Catra glanced at Adora as she drove, her heart swelling with affection and a newfound sense of purpose. Whatever the future held, she knew that they would face it together. And that thought brought her a deep, comforting sense of peace.

As they approached the town, the familiar sights and sounds began to emerge, but everything felt different. Their lives were changing, and for the first time, Catra felt ready to embrace whatever came next, as long as Adora was by her side.

"Hey," Adora said quietly, barely louder than a whisper as she stood on the doorstep, her hands stuffed into her jacket pockets.

The first thing Adora noticed when her mom opened the door was the shock on her face. How pale her face is. Then the tears in her eyes.

Before Adora could react, her mother rushed forward, wrapping her in a suffocating hug. The sudden force caused Adora to stumble back, caught off guard by the intensity. Her arms awkwardly hovered for a moment before she hesitantly returned the embrace.

“I’m so glad you’re safe.”

The words, though comforting, carried a weight that made Adora’s chest tighten. She hadn’t expected this reaction. Not from her. For a brief moment, she stood frozen, unsure of how to respond.

Adora stepped into the house, the familiar scent of boiling tea filling the air. As she entered the kitchen, her dad was already seated at the dining table, his face a mask of grim silence. He didn’t look up, just stared into his cup. The steam swirled between them, creating a tension that felt impossible to break.

Her mom motioned for her to sit down. Adora hesitated for a moment before taking the seat across from her parents, her heart hammering in her chest. She thought her mom would start yelling —the fact that she wasn’t here for new years; the fact that she was gone for 3 days without saying anything.

But there was no anger. No yelling. Just the soft sound of tea being poured into three cups. The silence felt heavier than any words could’ve been, pressing down on her like a weight she couldn’t shake.

Adora’s eyes darted between her parents, waiting for the outburst, waiting for the accusations. But none came.

Finally, her mother broke the quiet, setting the teapot down with a soft clink. Her voice, usually sharp and decisive, was calm, almost too calm. “Aren’t you going to apologise?”

Adora's throat tightened as she searched for the right words. She glanced down at her hands, fingers nervously fiddling with the edge of her jacket.

“I apologise for not telling you I was leaving,” she said softly, her voice strained, but steady.

Her mother’s lips pressed into a thin line as she sat down across from Adora, her eyes narrowing slightly. "I think you should be apologizing for everything."

Adora blinked, caught off guard. "What did I do?"

Her mother’s expression hardened. "Making me worry? We were worried sick. I nearly called the police and filed a missing persons report, but your father stopped me." She paused, her voice growing colder. "You're so lucky he stopped me because you would’ve been in so much trouble."

Adora’s stomach sank. The weight of her mother’s words made her heart pound louder in her ears. She swallowed hard, forcing herself to meet her mother’s gaze.

"Where did you go?" her mom demanded, her voice still deceptively calm.

"I... I went to our lakehouse," Adora admitted, her words slow, careful.

Her mother leaned back in her chair, crossing her arms tightly over her chest. A bitter smile tugged at the corners of her lips, cold and sharp. “By yourself,” she repeated, her voice dripping with disbelief.

Adora’s pulse quickened. She could feel the conversation teetering toward dangerous territory. “Yeah… by myself.”

Her mom’s eyes flashed with something—anger, maybe disappointment—before she let out a low, humorless snicker. “You’re lying.”

Adora’s stomach lurched. She hated the way her mother could dismantle her with a single look, a single word. “What would make you say that?”

“Because I asked Catra’s mom where she was, and her mom told me she was spending New Year’s with you,”

“Why would you go to Catra’s house?”

“Because I knew you’d pull something like this,” she said slowly, savoring every word. “Right after we had our talk, you dared to go behind my back. You used my family’s premises to spend time with that… that…”

Adora’s blood boiled. She straightened up in her chair, her fists clenching under the table. “That? What, Mom?” Her voice cracked but held firm, her eyes blazing with a mix of defiance and hurt. “Don’t you dare say anything offensive about her.”

Her mom’s face twisted in a mixture of shock and fury. “Are you trying to threaten me?”

“Mom, this is Catra you’re talking about!” Adora shot back, her words tumbling out in a rush. “She’s been my best friend since we were kids! She used to stay over practically every week. You drove us to school, you picked us up! How can you sit there and talk like this about her?”

"She's changed, Adora. She's been different ever since her dad left. You know he kept her in check. He kept both of them in check. And after what she did to you…"

Adora’s fists clenched even tighter, the words burning in her throat. "Mom, she didn’t do anything. I told you this. A million times."

"I refuse to believe that, Adora." Her voice cracked, her hands trembling slightly as she pressed them to the table. "You’re my little girl. My precious, *miracle baby* . I don’t want to believe that about you. I can’t,"

The words felt like a punch to the gut, twisting the knife that had already been lodged there for years. Adora wanted to grab her things and bolt—run far away from the suffocating pressure of her mother’s expectations, the disappointment that was always lurking in the air.

But then she remembered what Catra had told her. Don’t run away. Don’t run from your problems. Face them. The words echoed in her head, grounding her, pulling her back from the edge.

Adora took a deep breath, her chest rising and falling slowly as she tried to steady herself. She looked at her mom, then at her dad, whose silence weighed as heavily as her mother’s words. She swallowed the lump in her throat, pushing past the fear that threatened to consume her.

“Mom… Dad…” Her voice was quiet but steady, each word measured, deliberate. “I’m gay.”

Her mom's face contorted in shock, her lips parting as if she couldn’t quite process what Adora had just said. Her hands, which had been resting on the table, began to tremble again. "Adora, please—"

“Let me finish." Adora’s voice was firmer this time, a little louder, a little stronger. "Please, let me finish. You can say anything you want after I’m done. Just—please."

Her mother hesitated, eyes narrowed, but eventually nodded, lips pressed into a thin line.

Adora swallowed hard, gathering her thoughts, the weight of the moment heavy on her chest. “I know you don’t want to hear this, but I am gay. And you can’t change that about me. And I know I don’t tick a lot of your boxes. But honestly, I really like the person I’m becoming.” She glanced at her father, his face still blank, unreadable, before continuing. “I like working hard to be smart. I like being athletic. Also, I’m actually really happy at college. It’s the happiest I’ve ever been.”

Her mother’s expression didn’t change. She just sat there, hands clenched around her cup, as if bracing for the impact of every word.

Adora took a deep breath, her voice softening. “I’ve made amazing friends, I love my classes, and I’ve learned more about myself than I ever knew before.” She paused, searching their

faces for any sign of understanding, but all she saw was a wall of emotionless stares. “And I love you guys, and I hope you can support me and be a part of my journey, because I’m just having such a great time right now.”

The silence that followed was deafening. Adora felt like she was holding her breath, waiting for something—anything—from them. Her mom’s face remained rigid, like she was holding back everything she truly wanted to say.

Finally, her mom broke the silence. “Are you done?”

Adora blinked, her throat tightening. “Yeah… yeah, I’m done.”

Her mom set her teacup down carefully, her fingers still trembling. “I think it’s time for you to leave.”

“What?”

“If you’re so happy at college,” her mom continued, her voice cold and distant, “then you should leave. You don’t need us anymore, right?”

Her father finally spoke up, his voice low and hesitant. “Wait a second—let’s not just shove her out.”

“No,” her mother cut in, her voice rising in anger now. “She said she’s happier without us, and it’s the happiest she’s ever been.”

Adora’s chest tightened, her pulse quickening as she tried to make sense of the situation spiralling out of control. “That’s not what I meant!”

Her father tried to intervene, his hand resting on the table between them. “Come on, she doesn’t mean—”

“She’s the happiest she’s ever been when we’re not around?” her mom snapped, the hurt lacing her voice now. “You don’t even appreciate what we’ve done for you.”

“I do!" Adora’s voice cracked, her desperation spilling out. "I’m appreciative of everything you guys did for me. I’m just also really happy doing this, being myself.”

“I put in all this effort, sacrificed so much, for what?”

“For what?! Are you serious right now?!”

Her father looked between them, his face creased with concern. “We still love you, Adora.”

“But you’d love me more if I was different, right?”

Her mother stood up abruptly, her chair scraping loudly against the floor. “Get out.”

Adora’s world tilted, the words ringing in her ears. She stood up slowly, her legs feeling like lead beneath her. “If that’s what you want.”

Her mother didn’t answer. She just stared at the ground, arms crossed, jaw clenched.

Adora felt like the ground had vanished beneath her feet. Her chest tightened, but she forced herself to move, to keep breathing. She turned without another word and headed upstairs, her footsteps heavy on the wooden steps. Each creak echoed in the silence that had settled over the house.

She pushed open her bedroom door and stared at the space she had grown up in—the posters on the wall, the books stacked on her desk, the photos of her and Catra from when they were kids. It felt suffocating now, a relic of a life she was no longer part of. Quickly, she threw a few things into her bag—her clothes, her journal, her phone charger—and slung it over her shoulder.

When she reached the bottom of the stairs, her dad was waiting by the front door. His face was etched with sorrow, his eyes downcast, but he tried to smile when he saw her.

“Adora… just give her time,” he said softly, his voice thick with emotion. “I love you, and so does she. She’s just… she’s emotionally raw right now.”

Adora’s heart twisted. She wanted to believe him, but the sting of her mother’s words was still fresh, still sharp. She nodded, trying to hold back the tears that were threatening to spill over.

“Okay, Dad,” she whispered, her voice barely audible.

He stepped forward and wrapped her in a tight hug, the kind of hug that made her feel small, like a kid again. “Stay safe, alright?” he murmured, his voice breaking slightly. “And don’t ever think we don’t love you.”

Adora closed her eyes, leaning into the warmth of his embrace. “I won’t.”

They pulled apart slowly, and she gave him one last look before turning toward the door. Her father’s hand lingered on the doorknob as he opened it for her, the cool night air hitting her face as she stepped outside.

Catra stepped through the front door, closing it quietly behind her. The familiar smell of coffee and the soft sound of dishes clinking in the sink drifted from the kitchen. She slipped off her shoes, her heart feeling a little lighter than usual as she made her way inside.

Her mom was sitting at the kitchen table, a steaming mug of coffee in hand. She looked up as Catra entered, her expression neutral, though her eyes lingered on Catra for a moment longer than usual.

"Welcome back," her mom said, taking a sip from her mug. "How are you?"

Catra shrugged as she slid into the chair opposite her. “Good.”

Her mom studied her over the rim of her cup. “You look happy.”

Catra raised an eyebrow, a small smile tugging at the corner of her lips. “Really? Maybe I am.”

Her mom nodded, setting her coffee down with a soft clink. “You didn’t work for three days—how are you going to pay your portion of the bills?”

Catra’s stomach tightened slightly, but she kept her tone calm. “I’ve been saving up, so it should be fine. I’ve got enough to

cover it.”

Her mom hummed, the sound low and noncommittal. “And your job’s fine with you slacking off work like that?”

Catra bristled, but she forced herself to keep her cool. “Yeah, I told my boss, and he’s okay with it. He knows I’m a good worker, so he didn’t mind.”

Her mom made that sound again—half-hum, half-sigh—as she lifted her mug back to her lips.

Catra’s eyes narrowed. “What’s that supposed to mean?”

Her mom set the mug down more deliberately this time. “No, it’s just... interesting business practices. Not every boss would be so lenient, that’s all.”

Catra leaned back in her chair, crossing her arms. The good mood she’d carried home from the lakehouse evaporated, replaced by the familiar sense of tension she always felt around her mom. “You knew I was going with Adora. Why are you mad at me?”

Catra’s mom set her coffee mug down with a deliberate clink, her eyes not quite meeting Catra’s as she leaned back in her chair.

"I’m not mad at you, Catra,” she paused. Her tone was a bit more smug. “Did she convince you to move in with her yet?"

Catra froze, caught off guard. Her mom’s voice was calm—too calm. It made her stomach twist. “...What’s it to you?”

Her mom shrugged, taking another sip of her coffee. “Well, I’ve gotta know if you’re going to be around much longer. Can’t just have you up and disappearing without telling me.”

“...Do you want me to stay?”

“You can do whatever you want, Catra,” her mom replied, her voice light and dismissive. “I already told you that.”

Catra swallowed hard, trying to push down the growing frustration. "Okay. Good. Because I’m thinking about leaving."

“And doing what?”

“College,” Catra said firmly.

“College?” Her mom scoffed, a short, humorless laugh escaping her lips.

“You don’t think I can?”

“Catra, darling, you have your strengths, and you have your weaknesses,” Her mom leaned forward, her tone almost gentle. “And your strength has never been academics.”

The words cut through Catra like a knife. She clenched her fists under the table, trying to keep her voice steady. “Okay…”

“I just don’t want you to get your hopes up,” her mom continued, sipping her coffee as though she hadn’t just torn Catra down. “There are some things you’re good at, and some things... well, it’s better to know your limits.”

Catra’s throat tightened. "I’m not asking you to support me. I’m telling you I’m going."

“You’re no Adora,”

Catra felt the words strike her like a physical blow. Her heart clenched, the familiar sting of comparison rising in her chest, but this—this was different. It wasn’t just some offhand comment from a stranger or a passing thought she’d long buried. This was her mom. The one person who was supposed to see her for who she was, not who she wasn’t.

Her voice came out shaky, barely above a whisper. "What's that supposed to mean?"

Her mom sighed, giving Catra a patient, almost pitying look. "It just means that you need to be realistic, Catra. Adora... well, she's always been this successful go-getter, you know? The kind of person who was bound to leave this town and do great things. But you?" She paused, her eyes flicking over Catra like she was sizing her up. "You're different. You've always been more loyal to what's here. To the people who've raised you, this town, your family." She gestured vaguely toward herself, as if to underscore the point. "That's where your strengths lie. That's where you're safe. Where it's familiar."

Catra's fists clenched in her lap. "So, what? You think I should just... what, give up?"

Her mom's face hardened, her voice dropping an octave. "You're not giving up. You're being smart. You've never been like Adora—driven by these big dreams of escaping. You're not like her. You've always been here, dependable. And there's nothing wrong with that."

Dependable. Loyal.

"I'm going upstairs," she simply said, her eyes staring into the abyss.

“Are you having a nap, darling?”

“Yeah, I have work in a few hours so I’ve gotta get ready for that. My boss says that I might be promoted to manager soon,” her voice is flat.

“Well that’s great. I suppose they see that you’re loyal and you’ll stay at your job.”

Loyal. “Yeah, I guess they do.”

Chapter 18

“Catra,”

It was red. Her jacket. Her cheeks. Her eyes.

Adora's car was haphazardly parked outside, bags piled in the backseat. It took only a second for Catra to understand what was going on—things hadn’t gone well.

“We need to go, Catra. We need to go.” Adora’s voice was shaky, desperate.

Catra stood in the door frame. Caught midway to her room to have a nap before her shift. Her mind elsewhere from the conversation she just had with her mom. She imagined her past. She thought about her future. She sighed.

“I’m not leaving.”

The words came out flat, emotionless. Catra’s chest tightened as she said it, but she forced herself to stay steady.

Adora blinked, her expression faltering. Her face contorted with confusion and hurt and agony. “What?”

“I’m not leaving,” Catra repeated, a little louder this time, her words almost clipped.

Adora’s face crumpled, the confusion and pain clear in her wide eyes. “What? But… our plan? What happened?”

Catra swallowed hard, her throat tight. She wanted to explain everything, wanted to tell Adora what her mom had said, how it had all come crashing down around her. But the words wouldn’t come.

“Plans change, Adora.”

Adora’s breath hitched, her voice trembling as she took a step closer. “But we made a promise."

"Yeah, well..."

"You promised me!" she cried. "W e were supposed to be together.”

Catra’s heart cracked, but she stood firm. She clenched her fists at her sides, trying to keep herself from falling apart. “Then why can’t you stay?” Catra asked, her voice rising. “You said you wouldn’t leave me this time.”

Adora shook her head, her voice pleading. “I’m not leaving you. I admit I was wrong last time—I should’ve told you sooner, I know, but right now… I need you, Catra. I need you, and we need to go.”

Catra could feel the desperation radiating off of Adora, and it almost broke her resolve. Almost. But she couldn’t shake her mother’s words, the suffocating reality of her life here. The future felt too uncertain, too impossible. And she couldn’t drag Adora into that.

"Well I needed you a year ago and where the hell were you?!" she screamed. Adora stopped. "And I need you right now. I need you to stay. With me, right here, in our town. In *our* home. Please, this time...just stay."

"But I *need* us to go," Adora begged. "Please Catra, please understand that."

“I can’t go, Adora,” Catra’s voice softened, but the firmness remained. “I can’t just pack up and leave like it’s that easy.”

“Why not?”

“This is all I know. It’s all I have,” she muttered. "This town? This home. It's my life, it everything."

“No, Catra. You’re more than this. You’re better than this crap little town. You need to trust me, okay?” Her voice was firm, her eyes wide with sincerity. “I’ll be with you every step of the way—”

“Until you get bored again and leave?” Catra cut her off, her words laced with bitter frustration. She let out a hollow laugh, shaking her head. “You’re an ambitious go-getter, Adora. You always need to reach for something more. You keep trying to grow higher and higher, and you’re going to outgrow everything—college, your job, maybe even this country.”

Adora shook her head, stepping even closer, her voice softening. “That’s not true.”

Catra met her gaze, her expression hardened, though the pain in her eyes was unmistakable. “I’m fine here, Adora. I might not be the next rockstar like you, but I’m constant. I’m consistent. I’m dependable.”

“I’m not going to outgrow you,” Adora whispered.

Adora didn’t have an answer that would fix everything, no promise that could erase the fear Catra had of being left behind. She wished she could take that pain away, the uncertainty that seemed to cling to every word Catra said.

“I’m sorry.”

Catra slowly closed the door.

Adora stood alone in the winter air.

Chapter 19

Chapter Notes

Sorry it's been over a year since I updated. I was busy becoming a lawyer (true story - law school is a bitch btw).

But we're finally back with the fic!

6AM.

The alarm blared through the dorm room with mechanical precision, and Adora’s eyes flew open the instant it rang. Not a second later. No snooze. No second thoughts.

She sat up, exhaling sharply into the cold morning air, her breath fogging slightly. The room was still dark, lit only by the faint sliver of dawn peeking through the blinds. Her limbs were heavy, the kind of weight that wasn't just physical. But she didn’t let herself think too much about it. Not yet.

Her routine took over. Hair first. She tied it into a high, tight ponytail — tight enough to pull at her forehead and keep her focus sharp. Then leggings. Sports bra. Activewear top. Hoodie over the top.

She zipped it halfway, stepped into her sneakers, and headed out. The hallway was quiet. Mostly because no one came back yet from the holidays. She didn’t care if she was one of the only people on campus. She couldn’t care less. She preferred it.

Outside, the cold slapped her full in the face. The kind of sharp air that stung your cheeks and sliced into your lungs. She stood at the edge of the path and bounced on her feet, running on the spot, trying to trick her body into warmth. Her breath came out in short, white puffs, the rhythm syncing with the beat of her heart.

Then she ran.

Around campus, past the library, the dorms, the quiet gym building, and the rows of frostbitten benches near the student quad. The cold kissed her skin through the hoodie, but she pushed harder, her legs pumping, her thoughts tangled.

She told herself she didn't care. About Catra. About what happened. About how they stood there, not saying what needed to be said, and still said too much.

But that wasn't true. Of course it wasn't true.

Because she did care. Deeply. Too deeply. That's why she was out here in the freezing dark at six in the damn morning, trying to outrun her thoughts.

Catra left me, she reminded herself, *just like I left her a year ago.*

She deserved it, didn’t she?

Maybe that’s what karma was. Not some cosmic punishment, just a reflection. An echo. A closed loop of pain and regret. Maybe this was balance, and Adora just had to swallow it.

She kept running. One foot, then the other. Forward. Always forward. She tried to empty her mind, tried to let the pain slip from her chest and into the pavement beneath her sneakers. But Catra’s face wouldn’t leave her—cold in the snow, eyes tired, voice too soft when she said, “I can’t go, Adora.”

“I can’t go, Adora.”

“I can’t go, Adora.”

By the time she stopped, she didn’t even realize she had ended up at the outdoor seating of the student café, chest heaving. Her body was warm, finally, but her thoughts weren’t any clearer.

“Hey!” Bow’s voice startled her out of the fog.

She looked up and found him already sitting at a table, nursing a steaming coffee, his laptop open, earbuds coiled beside it. He was sat at the only cafe on campus open so early. Pretty much only ever filled by engineering, medicine and law students. So it was no surprise that Bow was here.

“What are you doing out here this early?” he asked, lifting a brow. “You look like you ran through a blizzard.”

Adora flopped down across from him, sweat dampening her hoodie, her ponytail fraying around her face.

“I basically did,” she said with a breathless laugh, wiping her forehead.

Bow laughed. "Care to join me?"

"Would love to."

So she got herself a coffee. A long black. Not her usual choice by any means but she was hoping that the bitterness mixed with the warmth would fill up her chest, especially when it felt so empty.

Adora settled herself back down across from Bow. She took one deep breath - and just let everything out. What is was like going back. How her mom reacted. What Christmas was like. How it all ultimately ended. And how it felt when Catra pushed her away at the door, even though she begged her to come. She told him about the silence. The phone calls that never came. The snow piling up between them.

Bow didn’t interrupt. He didn’t even sip his coffee, just listened, his gaze steady and warm in a way that made Adora’s chest ache.

When she finally ran out of words, Bow exhaled softly. “Adora… look. You’ve been given this chance. Space to figure out who you are outside that small town. That’s not something everyone gets. It’s hard, I get it—it sucks that Catra’s not here with you—but you can’t force her to come. You can’t force her to do anything she’s not ready for.”

Adora’s throat tightened. She wanted to argue, but the truth of his words sat heavy in her chest.

Bow leaned in, folding his arms on the table. “At the end of the day, it’s about compromise. That’s what relationships are. It’s not about one person bending until they break. It’s about finding that middle ground.”

“But I can’t imagine my life without her,” Adora said, the words coming out almost like a plea. Her eyes burned as she clutched the coffee cup tighter. “She’s been with me my whole life. She’s… she’s it, Bow.”

Bow’s expression softened. He tilted his head. “Then maybe that means you’ve gotta do a bit of giving, too.”

The silence that followed was heavy but not unkind. Adora stared down at the steam curling from her coffee, hearing Catra’s voice

in her head all over again: *I can't go, Adora.*

Catra's life should've seemingly gone back to normal, right? Nothing has changed. Technically. Work is still as usual. Her mom is acting like nothing happened. Except everything happened. Adora happened.

She had the most magical few weeks of her life and now everything is…back to normal. And for some reason, it felt off to her now. It should've just been back to the schedule but she couldn't help but to compare her life now to the way it was with Adora. And how much she preferred it with Adora.

"Hey, what's going on?"

It was her and Scorpia during their lunch break. The bell rang above them as they entered Kyle's corner store to pick up a few things for lunch. Scorpia dusted off her work pants before swinging open the fridge to grab herself and Catra a chocolate milk each.

"What do you mean?" she took the milk with her left hand, then grabbed a sandwich on the shelf with her right.

"You've been weird recently. Ever since—"

“Don’t,” Catra cut her off. “...finish that sentence.”

“So…” Scorpia began. “Have you talked to Adora?”

Catra shook her head, looking away as they walked down the aisle. "No."

"It’s been, like, two weeks," Scorpia pressed, her tone gentle but probing.

"I know," Catra muttered, her voice barely audible.

They walked in silence for a moment before Scorpia spoke again, her voice more hesitant. "So...are you guys still friends?"

Catra froze for a second, her breath catching in her throat. She felt the familiar burn of tears threatening to spill over. "I don’t know," she admitted, her voice cracking. She wiped her eyes quickly, trying to hide the fact that she was tearing up. "But it doesn’t even matter. She’s dead to me."

"You don’t mean that," Scorpia said softly, her concern clear in her voice.

Catra clenched her jaw, unwilling to meet Scorpia’s eyes. She didn’t know what she meant anymore.

They reached the register, and Kyle scanned their items. His usual easygoing grin spread across his face as he bagged their lunch. "Oh, did Adora leave already?"

Scorpia, quick to answer, nodded for Catra. "Yeah, she did. Had to head back to college."

Kyle's smile faded slightly. "That sucks."

"Yeah, but—" Scorpia cut in, her voice a little too cheerful, "we’re going to go visit her."

Catra’s head snapped to Scorpia, her eyes wide.

“It’s a big drive. Are you sure you want to go straight after work?” Kyle said with slight concern.

“Yep! We can’t wait to see her!”

The moment they left the store, Catra snapped at her. “Are you serious?!”

Scorpia gave her a sidelong glance, her smile fading slightly. "Catra, you need to see her. You miss her, and honestly, I think she misses you too. You don’t have to let things end like this."

Catra stared at the ground, her heart pounding in her chest. Everything in her screamed to stay put, to bury it all and move on. But a small part of her—a part she hated admitting even existed—wanted to go, wanted to see Adora again.

"...I can’t," she finally whispered.

Scorpia stopped walking, turning to face Catra fully. "Yes, you can. You just don’t want to. And that’s okay, I get it. But if you don’t face this, you’re never going to be able to move on, and neither will she."

Catra looked up at Scorpia, her throat tight with emotion. "What if… what if it’s too late?"

"It’s not too late, Catra," Scorpia said gently. "Not if you try."

For a moment, Catra stood frozen, torn between the fear of rejection and the pull of something deeper—something she wasn’t sure she was ready to admit.

The road stretched out endlessly before them, dark and winding under the blanket of the night sky. Snow flurries danced in the beams of the headlights, swirling like tiny ghosts in the air. Inside the car, Scorpia had the radio cranked up, belting out the lyrics to some old pop song with wild enthusiasm.

Catra sat in the passenger seat, her arms crossed, staring out the window. She couldn't help but smirk as Scorpia sang along, way off-key but full of energy. "This is the best thing ever, Catra!" Scorpia said with a laugh, as she pounded the steering wheel to the beat.

"Sure, it is," Catra muttered, rolling her eyes. But her annoyance was only half-hearted, a cover for the tight knot of anxiety growing in her stomach. The truth was, she wasn't thinking about Scorpia's singing. She was thinking about her. Adora. "I can't believe you convinced me to do this."

It had been two weeks since they last spoke.

Two weeks since everything fell apart. And now, they were on the way to see her—unannounced. As the miles slipped by, Catra thought about texting her, giving her a heads-up, but every time she reached for her phone, her fingers froze. What would she even say?

The silence between her and Adora had been suffocating. But breaking it felt just as impossible.

“So,” Scorpia finally said, drumming her fingers against the steering wheel, “Why do you even stay in that town, anyway? You’ve got the whole online school thing, right?”

Catra’s head snapped up. “How do you know about that?”

Scorpia gave her a sheepish smile. “Uh, when I came by your place last week? I saw the test papers lying around.”

Catra groaned, dragging a hand down her face. “Seriously? You’re snooping through my stuff now?”

“I wasn’t snooping!” Scorpia said quickly, glancing at her before returning her eyes to the road. “They were just… there. But come on, Catra, why stay? You could be anywhere.”

“Because my mom needs me,” Catra said flatly. Her hands tightened in her lap.

Scorpia frowned. “She’s got the house, yeah, but doesn’t she want the best for you?”

Catra hesitated. Her throat felt dry. “…Maybe. I don’t know. But she needs me to stay.”

“What about what you need?” Scorpia asked gently.

Catra let out a bitter laugh. “Who cares about what I need?”

“I do.” Scorpia’s voice was soft but firm. She gave a sweet smile over which Catra rolled her eyes at. “But forget me for a second. Hypothetically, if you could do anything, go anywhere—what would you do?”

Catra went quiet. Her chest rose and fell, her eyes fixed on the blur of the highway outside the window. The answer caught her off guard—not because it was complicated, but because it was so simple.

And she unfortunately let herself think about it. She let herself imagine a world outside this town. What it would be like to attend classes in person. To try coffee that wasn't from that disgusting diner.

She bit down on her lip. "I don't know."

Hours passed in a blur of snow-covered trees, quiet highways, and Scorpia’s unrelenting chatter. When they finally pulled into the parking lot of Adora’s dorm building, it was almost 11 PM. The

campus was eerily quiet, the snow beginning to pile up on the pavement.

Catra swallowed the lump in her throat and pulled out her phone, her fingers trembling slightly as she dialed Adora's number. It rang once—just once—before Adora picked up.

"Hello?" Adora's voice was soft but tinged with surprise. "Catra? Is that you?"

"Hey," she replies, breath raspy. She felt like an idiot. She drove all the way here, and she couldn't even face her. "Yeah, it's me."

She could hear Adora's voice hitch on the other side. "H-How have you been? It's been a while. Look, I've been meaning to call you but…" she trailed off as if Catra was supposed to jump in. She didn't, so Adora continued. "...I guess I thought you were mad at me. For leaving…again."

"I was mad at you," she admitted.

"Yeah…" her voice expressed acceptance. "Are you still…mad?"

"I don't know. Maybe,"

“I’m sorry for how things worked out,” Catra heard Adora shuffling in the background. “I actually thought about coming down to see you in a few weeks. After I settle into a new dorm and all that. I know it’s not exactly how you planned it but I thought I’d go home more. Now to see my mum or anything but just to—”

“You dumbass,” Catra interjected. Adora stopped. “Look outside.”

Adora’s breath caught in her throat as she yanked the curtain aside. And there she was. Catra. Standing alone in the snow, her jacket zipped to her chin, hair damp with flakes that melted against her cheeks. A lone figure beneath the streetlight, half-buried in winter’s weight.

For a moment, Adora couldn’t breathe. Couldn’t move. She just stared, her heart pounding against her ribs like it wanted to break free.

“Catra…” The name slipped out of her mouth like a prayer.

On the phone, Catra’s voice was quiet, shaky, almost too soft for her. “Surprise.”

Adora dropped the curtain and practically bolted for the door, barely remembering to grab her dorm keys on the way. Her socks slid against the linoleum as she rushed down the stairs, skipping entire steps two at a time.

When she pushed open the door, the cold slammed into her instantly, sharp and biting. But she didn't care. Because Catra was right there—real, tangible, not just a memory or a ghost in her chest.

"Catra," Adora said again, her voice breaking this time.

Catra shoved her hands deeper into her jacket pockets, her usual defiance dimmed by nerves. "Hey. Figured I'd…drop by."

"Drop by?" Adora let out a shaky laugh, half incredulous, half relieved. "At eleven at night?"

Catra's mouth quirked up, but it didn't quite reach her eyes. "Well, I've never been great at timing."

Adora stepped forward before she could second-guess it, closing the distance. The snow crunched under her sneakers. She stopped just inches away, close enough to see Catra's uneven breaths, close enough to feel the tension radiating between them.

"You're freezing," Adora whispered, her voice gentler now. "What were you thinking, standing out here?"

“I was thinking…” Catra’s throat bobbed, her breath rising in pale clouds. “I didn’t want to warn you. Because if I warned you, you’d have time to say no. And then I wouldn’t be here.”

Her words cut through the night, raw and unguarded.

Adora blinked at her, phone still pressed against her ear, though the sound of Catra’s voice carried easily in the frozen air. The phone felt ridiculous now, like a flimsy barrier between them. She lowered it slowly, her gloved fingers trembling.

“Well,” Adora murmured, her chest tightening, “I’m happy to see you. I wasn’t lying when I said I was thinking about coming back more often.”

Catra’s eyes flickered with something—hope, maybe, though it was buried under caution. “…Yeah?” she asked, her voice barely audible over the wind.

“Yeah.”

There was a beat of silence before Catra shifted, her boots crunching against the snow. “I’ve been… thinking, too. About doing some stuff outside of town. Just little things. I’m still scared, though. Scared of what my mom will say. But I don’t want to keep putting it off forever.”

Adora’s brow furrowed softly. “What do you mean?”

“I mean…” Catra exhaled sharply, fogging the air between them. “I want to do college eventually. Properly."

"What?!" her voice was so much louder than she originally intended.

"B-But I don’t want to jump into moving out or doing everything at once. I’m not ready for that. Not yet,"

Adora studied her for a long moment, then said, “So… start small."

"Yeah,"

"Stay with me a few days,"

"What?"

"Just to test out the waters. No pressure, no big decisions. Just… see what it feels like,"

Catra blinked at her, taken aback. “Stay with you?”

“Yeah. Just for a bit.”

Before Catra could form a response, another voice cut in. “If you’re worried about me, don’t be,” Scorpia said cheerfully from where she leaned against her car. “I’ve got an internet friend who lives around here. I’ll crash with her.”

Catra whipped around, narrowing her eyes. “Wait. Is *that* why you wanted to drive me in the first place?”

Scorpia froze, her wide smile faltering into a guilty grimace. “… Maybe?”

Adora bit back a laugh, glancing between them, while Catra just groaned into her hands.

Adora tilted her head, watching Catra with a softness she couldn’t quite hide. “So… what do you say?”

Catra huffed out a breath. “Fine. I’ll stay.”

“But only because I’m not in the mood to freeze to death in Scorpia’s car.” Catra smirked, sharp but playful, the edge of it softening as she added, “Don’t get a big head about it.”

Adora let out a shaky laugh, the tension in her shoulders unraveling. “Right. Of course. Just… survival instincts.”

“Exactly.” Catra’s smirk grew, though there was a flicker of something else behind it—something unspoken, fragile, almost hopeful.

Scorpia clapped her hands together, breaking the moment. “Great! Settled then! One sleepover at Adora’s, one awkward meetup with my internet friend. Win-win!”

Catra groaned, but this time, she didn’t fight the smile tugging at the corners of her mouth.

Chapter 20

The room was quiet except for the hum of the radiator and the soft clinking of Adora's keys in her hand. She spun them absently around her finger, the little bells on the keychain jingling in uneven bursts—bright, cheerful, a kind of accidental soundtrack to the morning.

Their apartment wasn't big, but it was theirs. Two bedrooms, a narrow kitchen, and a living room with sun-stained curtains. Compared to the chaos of dorm life, it was peace. Twenty minutes off campus, tucked into a sleepy street that smelled faintly of pine and coffee grounds, it was far enough to breathe but close enough to still make their classes on time—well, sometimes.

It hadn't always been this way. For two years, they'd lived with roommates, and every memory of it made Adora wince. Blasting music at 3 a.m., dishes stacked in the sink until the smell made the whole place unlivable, arguments over who "borrowed" what from the fridge. Privacy was rare, tension constant. And back then, Adora thought moving in together was the obvious next step, the easy solution.

But Catra had hesitated. She wanted her own space, her own stretch of independence before their lives folded into one another again. At the time, Adora hadn't fully understood, but now she was grateful they'd waited. The patience had given them this. Something steadier. Something real.

Her eyes landed on the chair by the window, draped with a hand-knitted scarf in uneven shades of blue and green. Catra had given

it to her on their first Christmas. That was forever ago.

The bells chimed again as Adora twirled her keys, “Hurry up, Catra,” she called, her voice bright but threaded with fondness.

A muffled groan drifted out from the bedroom, followed by the shuffle of feet across the carpet.

Catra emerged, tugging irritably at the collar of her graduation gown. The dark fabric swished around her ankles, a little too big on her frame, the sleeves hanging past her wrists in a way that made her look both regal and faintly ridiculous.

Underneath, though, Adora caught the glimpse of what she’d chosen to wear—black trousers, sharp and fitted, with a deep red blouse tucked neatly at the waist. A thin silver chain hung on her wrist.

Adora’s breath caught, excitement bubbling up and spilling out before she could hold it back. “You look amazing!” she said, grinning so wide it almost hurt. She jumped to her feet, keys forgotten in her palm. “Oh my god, Catra, it’s really happening!”

Catra rolled her eyes, but the corner of her mouth twitched into a smirk as she adjusted the gown again. “Yeah, yeah. Guess it’s finally my turn now.”

That faithful day when Catra first showed up at Adora's dorm, she had been hesitant—nervous, cold from the snow, and unsure if she was doing the right thing. But she stayed. Just for a bit. And those few days turned out to be nothing short of magical. Catra wandered through the campus, eyes wide at the sprawling lawns dusted in autumn gold, the library with its towering windows that caught the light just so, the quiet little courtyard where students lounged and read, laughing over coffees in the crisp air. Everything felt larger than life, alive, and safe in a way she hadn't anticipated.

Yet, even amidst the beauty and freedom, a small, gnawing fear lingered at the back of her mind—what would her mom say? Could she justify this to her, or would it all come crashing down? When the day came to leave, Adora had offered without hesitation to go with her, to back her up, to stand by her side. Together, they faced the moment. They explained everything honestly, every choice, every plan. Catra's mom had been silent the whole time, her expression unreadable, giving nothing away. In that quiet, almost unbearable pause, Catra made a decision: she was going to do this for herself.

The first few months were tough. There were days when guilt clawed at her, and she felt the weight of her hometown pressing down. They went no-contact with her mom for a while, a painful but necessary boundary. Still, Catra made every effort to keep returning, working part-time, contributing to rent, navigating her classes, proving to herself—and quietly to her mom—that she could stand on her own. Gradually, it seemed that her mother dropped the subject, leaving Catra the space she had fought so hard for.

“Your mum should be meeting us there,” Adora said, grabbing her bag. “I gave her the address.”

“You know how she is—she gets lost so easily. Especially out of town.”

Adora smiled, though there was something punching at her chest. Adora had never reached out to her own mother again. Her dad checked in after a few weeks, hesitant but steady, but her mom’s silence had become permanent. And so it was that when graduation day came, the only person who showed up for Adora in that sea of robes and excited chatter was her father.

Catra tugged gently on Adora’s sleeve, snapping her out of her reverie. “Hey,” she said, her voice soft, tinged with an awkwardness that only she could manage. “I’m sorry your mom didn’t come to yours.”

Adora shook her head, a small smile lifting the corners of her mouth. “It’s okay. At least my dad came.”

Catra’s face softened, a warmth spreading across her features. “He’s the best,” she murmured, and it wasn’t just about the graduation—she meant it, about the man who had quietly supported Adora in the ways that mattered most.

They lingered in the apartment a moment longer before leaving, taking it all in. The small kitchen with its chipped paint, the living

room where sunlight pooled across the rug in the mornings, the books and little mementos scattered across the shelves—they had made this space their own. Each item told a story.

Standing there, they could see how far they'd come. From neighbors to best friends to now—girlfriends, partners, a team. They had pushed and pulled, stumbled and caught each other, sometimes falling, sometimes flying, but always together. Pride swelled in their chests, quiet but fierce, a recognition of the distance traveled, the obstacles faced, and the love that had grown stronger for it.

Adora thought about the years that had passed, about the way she had once run from her fears and ambitions, from the uncertainty of her heart. She had chased her future with a determined streak, yes, but she had stayed when it mattered. She had been there for Catra through heartbreak, confusion, and doubt. She had finally stopped hiding, finally faced the truths she had once avoided, and now—even without her mother's approval—she could live honestly, fully, without apologies. She could be exactly who she was, and she didn't have to shrink for anyone.

Catra, for her part, had learned to accept the love that Adora gave without resistance. It hadn't been instant, hadn't been easy. She had feared the freedom of opening herself completely, worried she would be tethered by responsibility or guilt. But now, with Adora beside her, she could step into the world on her own terms. She could chase her dreams, explore new horizons, and still have a home, a heart, a love to return to. She could live for herself, unafraid and unbound.

The apartment seemed to hum with memory and promise, the space between them filled with all that they had endured and all that they had yet to discover. Without speaking, they shared the quiet acknowledgment of every laugh, every tear, every moment that had led them here.

Then, finally, they turned to each other, eyes meeting with the same certainty that had never faltered in all the years they had grown together.

“I love you,” Adora whispered.

“I love you too,” Catra replied

And that’s how it ended—not with fireworks or grand proclamations, but with the simple, perfect truth of two people who had found their way to each other, fully and completely.

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